

deliver



refine through practice

You've planned and created your content. But amazing content can fall flat if it isn't communicated well. In this chapter, we concentrate our attention on *you*—the presenter.

When you are the one talking through your analysis, project, or presentation, you play a critical role in that process. Consider presentations that you've sat through in the past. If you're like me, they run the gamut, from awful to awesome. Which end of that spectrum they fall closer to often depends primarily on one thing: the person communicating the information. Does the way they talk make me want to listen?

I once attended a conference where there was a short presentation about a rare bird in New Zealand (the *kākāpō*, which is in danger of becoming extinct). I didn't intentionally choose this session; it was a single-track event, and I happened to be sitting in a comfortable chair near friends I don't get to see often. I was surprised at how intriguing I found the topic. It did not engage me because I was interested in this particular subject matter, but because the presenter was clearly so passionate about it. That type of excitement is contagious. I could see how much he cared about the topic, and it actually made *me* care more than I otherwise would have. The speaker used some good visuals, too, but those were icing on the cake. *He* was the one who made it engaging.

A polished presenter is able to overcome mediocre materials. The opposite is not true. You may have fantastic content: great images, beautiful data visualizations, and thoughtfully designed slides—but if you can't get people's attention and talk in a way that will resonate, you run the risk of all of your hard work being for naught.

Don't let that happen! Here's the best part: we can all be great presenters.

This doesn't magically occur. It takes time and careful, active practice. All of this transpires behind the scenes, so it's easy to overlook. You don't observe the work that goes into developing a good presenter; you only witness the results when you see it done well. Have you ever watched a skillful presenter and thought to yourself: I wish I had that talent for public speaking; how lucky they are to feel comfortable and confident in front of an audience!

TED talks are a great case in point. An unassuming person walks onto the stage, looking effortlessly put together, and delivers a spectacular presentation of inspiring content. It sometimes seems like they aren't even trying!

If you rewind the tape, what you *don't* see are the months of expert planning and coaching that go into making those twenty minutes look so easy.

I certainly didn't start out as a confident public speaker, and it showed through my shaky hands, wavering voice, and abundance of filler words. My presentation skills are the result of deliberate preparation and a great deal of practice. Over time, I have cultivated this ability in myself and in my team. As a result, I am an absolute believer that we can all become increasingly effective and nuanced in the role that we play when we communicate.

In this chapter and the following, we'll study specific strategies and tactics to employ while you prepare yourself to present with poise. This chapter centers on how to practice presenting specific content you have developed. We'll examine concrete ways to do so that will help you both continue to refine your

supporting slides and be well positioned to deliver them adeptly. In Chapter 10, we'll sharpen the focus on you and build your confidence as a presenter.

Let's begin with the simple practice of saying things out loud.

Practice out loud

My number one tip as you prepare to speak in any important scenario—whether seated around a table with colleagues, presenting virtually, or standing on a stage—is to spend time practicing aloud.

One important aspect that we pay more attention to when we practice audibly is our transitions. Specifically, I am referring to the shifts between slides, graphs, or topics. When you sit at your desk and advance through slides on your computer, it helps you become clear about what you want to say on each slide. However, it's easy to skip thinking about how you'll get from one to the next. When you talk through your content out loud, you are forced to articulate this step. You have to find the words that actively connect the pieces for yourself and for others. Doing this will both help you form thoughtful transitions and continue to improve your content so that it works well to support your spoken words. Good transitions take a presentation from feeling haphazard or disjointed to polished and smooth.

There are benefits to practicing out loud in a few different manners. When I'm preparing to give an important presentation, I'll practice my content aloud in slide sorter view, one slide at a time, and finally, without my slides. Let's discuss each of these approaches.

Practice out loud: slide sorter view

Recall that I suggested you talk through your story aloud way back in Chapter 4 when we were arranging ideas along the narrative arc. We brought that storyline into slideware in Chapter 5 and vetted the flow (at that point, with

simple titles on empty slides) in slide sorter view. Now that you have your content fleshed out, this is a great time to look at it again from this perspective and talk through it.

This helps you test the general order, form smooth transitions, and start to commit the progression to memory. It can also highlight specific adjustments to make so your content better supports you. If something feels off or you're having a hard time figuring out how to move from one slide to another, this often indicates that changing the order or introducing additional connecting content will help. Doing this with a static view of your slides also allows you to identify whether and when animation (elements appearing, becoming transparent, or disappearing) on a given slide may prove useful, too. We'll look at a specific example of this in the case study at the end of this chapter.

Say it out loud

Speaking aloud helps us refine, practice, and identify better solutions—for our graphs, slides, and overarching presentations. I've long been an advocate of this simple and underutilized strategy. To hear more on this idea, check out Episode 6 of the *storytelling with data* podcast, entitled "say it out loud" (storytellingwithdata.com/podcast).

Practice out loud: one slide at a time

Once you're comfortable with the general flow, it is often useful to talk through your deck slide by slide. Whereas your review in slide sorter view is likely to stay at a higher level, this is where you will identify specific speaking points. You can test the appropriate level of detail to go into on each slide and get comfortable with the words you'll use and the general order you'll approach things. Doing this several times (particularly if there's a piece that's tripping you up) will allow you to test out different strategies and figure out what works best.

We'll come back to the practice of talking aloud through your slides a little later in this chapter when I encourage you to do a full dry run emulating the environment in which you'll ultimately present. For now, use your audible practice to clearly articulate your main points and make sure your content is set up to support you well. If there's something important that you're afraid of forgetting, build prompts directly into your slides. For example, add or animate a reminder word, phrase, or point of emphasis to bring it to your attention. Be aware of rough patches or anything that's tripping you up—either continue to practice until it feels smooth or modify your content. If you have the benefit of additional time, return to any problem areas after you've taken a break. With a fresh mind, you may have better success.

How much should I practice?

I am an advocate of practicing until you feel comfortable with your content and are able to talk through it eloquently. That's going to look a little different as the situation changes. In this chapter, I share the comprehensive varieties of practice that I personally combine for a high-stakes presentation. This doesn't mean that you have to follow each of these strategies every time you present. In some cases, a single run-through in slide sorter view might suffice; in others, you may practice one transition many times to make it smooth. Choose the method that will best suit your needs given your comfort with your topic, time constraints, and other factors. The more important the occasion, the more time I'd recommend devoting to practicing.

I've heard the notion that over-rehearsing is a bad thing, but I disagree. If you prepare to the point that you feel comfortable with your content, it leaves some brainpower free to pay attention to other things when you ultimately present. For example, you can watch facial expressions of those in the room and adjust your delivery in response or move about the physical space in intentional ways (which we'll discuss further in Chapter 12). The goal is to sound polished *without* sounding scripted.

When I'm getting clear on my main points for a given slide, I'll sometimes make use of speaker notes in my presentation software. To do this, add text in the pane below the slide in normal slide view (the same view where you edit slide content). I don't recommend writing out a full script, but adding a few words or short phrases to prompt your memory can be helpful (assuming you'll be able to see these notes when you present). You can also use speaker notes to reinforce key points or lend supporting details to your materials if someone else will be presenting them or if they will be shared with your audience.

Practice out loud: *without your slides*

I also advocate practicing out loud without your slides. I do this a lot. One benefit is that you can do it anywhere. I often take long walks around my neighborhood talking to myself, audibly reinforcing my content (fortunately, I don't usually run into too many neighbors when doing so!). This assists me in a couple of ways. First, it helps with the transitions that I mentioned before. Each time I move from one idea or concept to another, I expand the number of already-established pathways in my brain to pull from for smooth connections when I ultimately present. I hear how I sound and explore ways to use my voice (we'll discuss this in depth in Chapter 10).

Also, without my slides in front of me, I'm forced to anticipate and remember what's coming. Repetition is key here. The more often I do that, the easier the progression will be to recall. When I know what to expect, I can be clever in how I lead from what I'm saying currently into what I'm going to say next. As I do this aloud, I'm forming transitions and choosing my words while simultaneously thinking about what's coming—there's a lot going on in my brain! All of this effort spent ahead of time will ultimately make it easier for me to communicate in a composed and thoughtful way.

As an additional benefit to practicing without my slides, I sometimes forget the exact planned order of content and walk through something in a different manner that works better than what I originally designed. So this practice of talking aloud without slides illuminates improvements to make to my content, too.

Commit it to memory while you [...]

In the days leading up to presenting new content—this could be for a keynote address, a virtual event, or a training session—I practice any rough patches in my head as I brush my teeth. This is uninterrupted alone time where I work through different words and phrasing to come up with options. When I’m doing this, I’ll think through the same part a few times because I find the repetition helpful. The intermittent nature of this ritual (I don’t necessarily do it every time I brush: in some cases, it’s once in the morning and again that night or on consecutive mornings) also helps me commit the flow to memory. Consider when during your day you do something routine that doesn’t require active thought. Can you repurpose headspace during that time to hone your words and message?

I don’t advocate memorizing—it’s too risky. If you forget an important word or phrase that you want to say, it may throw everything off. But I am a fan of committing strategic points to memory. Something that is useful to nail down is the general progression of your material: what comes first, what comes after that, and so on. Practicing without slides helps you do this.

While I don’t recommend memorizing, I *do* encourage you to plan how you will start and the way you will end.

Plan the beginning and end

The beginning and end of your presentation are important points. The way you start is the first impression you will make on others. It’s in those initial few minutes that people decide whether they are going to continue to devote their attention to you or turn it to something else. Make those first moments especially count. Pique your audience’s interest—both for your topic as well as

for you and how you speak about your topic. At the other end of the spectrum is the way you wrap up your presentation: this is the final and lasting impression. Make it a positive one, too.

Start strong

Let's focus first on crafting the beginning. I plan the way I'll start any time I'm going to be discussing something new. I recently recorded a podcast where I interviewed a guest in person. In addition to audio, we also recorded video and streamed it to viewers watching live. With an audio-only podcast, I typically draft my introduction ahead of time, actually writing it out. Then I practice out loud a few times so it sounds natural by the time we record it.

Given the nature of this particular podcast, that technique wasn't going to work—I needed to connect with my guest and those watching, not read from a script. To achieve a strong start, I plotted the general flow. I would begin by introducing myself. I would give some context about my guest and why others would find him interesting. From there, I would delve into the story of how I got to know him and tell specific anecdotes to pique people's interest. Then I would jump into my first question. Those were the topics I wanted to hit and in that order.

I practiced aloud. The way I did it was a little different each time, and that was useful. I found distinct ways to get from points A to B to C to D, which gave me a lot of flexibility when I got to the eventual conversation—I knew I'd have various trajectories I could take. As another benefit of practicing out loud: in several instances, I'd realize I was talking down a path that I didn't want to follow. When practicing, it's easy to reign that back in and start again at a prior point. It's much better to learn from that process than to meander through my words while others are listening!

Knowing the points you're going to tackle at the beginning is also helpful if you're prone to nervousness when you speak in front of others. Having a clear plan on how you'll begin allows you to address those initial minutes with ease.

By the time you get through your introduction, your nerves will likely have calmed, allowing you to think better on your feet as you move through the rest of your content.

Plan the ending

It is equally important to be mindful about the close of your presentation. What feelings or ideas do you want to leave with your audience? Whether seeking to inspire your assemblage from on stage or sitting with colleagues around a meeting table and wanting them to remember your key point or act in light of the insights you've shared, the right ending can help facilitate it.

Make a powerful final statement

When I'm presenting, it's typically either on stage for a keynote-style presentation or at the front of a room full of people teaching a workshop. In both of these settings, I like to build to a crescendo of anticipation up to the end. Often, this means wrapping with a well-rehearsed illustrative example that reinforces key lessons to inspire attendees with what could be. Then I finish with a final message that encourages the audience to bring those same learnings into their own work. This closing statement will be intentional, planned ahead of time, and spoken with confidence. This also makes it clear that it is *the end*. Consider how you can make a powerful final statement and send people off inspired.

Make your ending match the occasion. At the conclusion of your topic in a business meeting, this might take the form of thanking your audience for their time, recapping next steps, or letting stakeholders know when the subsequent update will take place. If the final slide will be visible for a period of time (such as during discussion or Q&A), make smart use of the space by putting key

takeaways or your main message on it as a visual reminder to yourself and your audience.

Knowing how you will close helps you wrap up gracefully. Even in a more casual situation, I recommend being thoughtful about planning the end. It's your opportunity to leave your audience with something salient and form a positive lasting impression.

Get feedback from others

You've practiced aloud in a few ways and planned how you'll start and finish: now is a great time to get input from someone else to direct your continued refinement. When seeking feedback on your content and delivery, be thoughtful both about whom you get feedback from and what type of input will be most useful. This will help you target your efforts.

Determine who to ask for feedback

Whose feedback will serve you best? One spectrum of potential reviewers to deliberate is supporter versus critic. If you're lacking confidence, getting early feedback from a **supporter** is a good place to start. This gives you a boost and helps set you on the right path. Asking a superfan is also a good course of action if you're short on time since someone on your side will likely be more willing to work within your constraints.

If you have more time and depending on the scenario, it occasionally makes sense to ask for input from a **critic**. This could be someone who is particularly tough on you or who you anticipate may be resistant to the message you want to get across. There are a couple benefits to this. First, by inviting feedback from someone who is not on board, you'll develop a better understanding of a different point of view. This can help to identify what is causing opposition so you are able to thoughtfully address it. Also, simply reaching out to a critic and asking for feedback is a vulnerable thing to do, which sends a strong message. If the person complies and offers guidance, act upon it. This exchange may have

the added bonus of shifting them into the supporter category. Imagine you do this with someone who will be at the meeting where you'll present: they'll be rooting for you in a way they wouldn't have before you solicited their guidance.

Another aspect to consider when selecting the person to critique you is their level of familiarity with what you'll be communicating—will it be most helpful to talk to an expert or someone unfamiliar? On the **expert** side, someone with subject matter knowledge who can quickly process the content may have an easier time focusing on your delivery. They can also help you anticipate questions or let you know if you go off track or say anything overreaching, which is good to realize and address ahead of time. Ask an expert to take the counterposition—have them assume a different viewpoint or pose difficult questions. The more you practice foreseeing how things might take unexpected turns and prepare for them, the more proficient you'll be at dealing with any issues that arise during your final presentation.

When it comes to choosing **someone unfamiliar** with your topic, it may be useful to practice with a friend or family member who is distanced from what you will present. This can be helpful for figuring out if you're using inaccessible language or assessing the level of context you should set. Invite them to ask for clarification along the way, making it clear that you value their honest and direct feedback. The process of answering their questions forces you to articulate your rationale and land on different words and ways of explaining that you can subsequently roll into how you communicate.

Supporter input helps me refine my stories

When I need input, I often turn to my #1 fan—my husband, Randy. I know that he'll be candid and that he wants me to do well, so when he offers feedback, I listen. His observations often serve as a fresh perspective on whether I'm talking through concepts in an easy-to-understand way or if more simplification is necessary. He's also a masterful storyteller. I routinely seek his input on the stories I use to introduce content and illustrate or reinforce ideas. Who in your life can give you feedback to refine your presentations?

There are benefits to each of the aforementioned profiles. In critical situations or as you're simply looking to develop and hone your skills generally, it is often useful to get feedback from multiple people. Collecting various views also helps to validate opinions: one seemingly off-base comment may not warrant addressing, but if you're getting the same suggestion from multiple sources, it is worth listening to and adjusting accordingly.

Be specific about what feedback is needed

Also be clear on what type of feedback will be most useful for you from the given person. Do you want them to concentrate on the content and make sure the words you're using make sense? Or should they observe your delivery: how you're moving your body and the tone of your voice? Do you want them to raise questions and offer an assessment as you go or let you do your thing and wait until the end? Set expectations up front so the person giving you input will know what to watch for and feel comfortable voicing it.

Knowing what you want feedback on specifically helps you determine how to best run through content to get the desired input as well. For example, if you want to vet your general progression of content and get someone to review

for errors or issues, start in slide sorter view. Share your screen in a virtual setting or have someone sit by you as you talk through your plan, clicking through individual slides in your presentation software. This method invites a fluid conversation, where you convey thoughts about your planned approach and get feedback along the way. On the other hand, if you seek input on your delivery, present your slides formally from start to finish. In that case, agree up front to discuss feedback at the end so it won't interrupt your flow.

When facing constraints that will have implications on whether and what adjustments are possible, disclose those, too. If your important meeting is tomorrow and you're simply interested in fine-tuning, that will warrant a different type and level of feedback than a presentation that is weeks away and allows you flexibility to make sweeping changes. The more explicit you are about what you need and the limitations you face with those who will provide feedback, the more actionable and useful an evaluation you will likely receive.

Do a dry run

If you solicited feedback from someone else, it's possible you framed it as a true trial run, delivering your content from start to finish as you intend to in your final presentation. If feedback was minimal and you're feeling good about your materials and delivery, you may not have to do another. However, if you didn't seek feedback, tackled it differently, or made modifications based on input—I'm an advocate of doing a separate dry run on your own. Use the learnings from this process to make final tweaks to your content, ensure you get the timing right, get comfortable with technology, and sound polished.

Emulate the presentation environment

To the extent possible, model the details of your mock session after your anticipated environment. If you'll be seated at a table, sit down and proceed through slides from your computer. Practice looking up from your screen like you will when others are there watching and listening. Will you be presenting from a stage or standing in front of a room? Get up and advance slides with a

clicker. Look around the room as you talk, as you will in your final delivery. When preparing for a virtual presentation, focus on the camera while you speak.

Do as much as you can to make your practice presentation look and feel like the real thing.

Get comfortable with unfamiliar tech

If you'll be using any new technology, your dry run is a great time to become familiar with it. I touched on one example already. If you'll require a clicker to advance your slides, practice with one ahead of time (ideally, the same one, but if that's not possible, rehearsing with a surrogate is still worthwhile). If you know you'll use a handheld microphone, hold a placebo. Yes, it sounds silly (and will look funny, too!), but this allows you to work out important decisions ahead of time—if I have a clicker in one hand and a microphone in the other, what will I do if I want to take a sip of water?—so you feel more comfortable during your presentation.

This is especially the case for any technology that will impact your slide content or design. For instance, if you will present from a computer other than your own, anticipate challenges and prepare for them. As we discussed in Chapter 5, this may mean downloading special fonts on the presentation laptop or eliminating them altogether to avoid mishaps.

If you'll be in a virtual environment, practice with the technology you'll use to present (Zoom, Google Hangout, Microsoft Teams, Cisco WebEx, etc.). If possible, do this on your own or with a colleague *outside* of any official planning meetings. This gives you the flexibility to poke around without interruption, which will make it easier to take notes and commit to memory. Get comfortable sharing your screen, turning your video and audio on and off, and switching to other windows (e.g. chat, Q&A).

When I present virtually, I often use a switcher (my preferred device is the ATEM Mini Pro). This gadget allows me to pivot seamlessly between a livestream of me speaking and my slides, as well as picture-in-picture (where I have my slide as the primary visual, with a strategically placed camera feed of me within it or vice versa). If I plan to present this way, I design my slides with a placeholder where the picture-in-picture box will appear to ensure everything works well together with sufficient space and without any elements overlapping. Even though I use the switcher fairly regularly, I always find some kinks to work out when I incorporate it in my practice run.

You can even go so far as to wear the clothes and accessories that you will when you present. This may sound strange, but doing this helps you catch potential issues before they become real problems. If the shoes you plan to stand in for your hour-long presentation become uncomfortable after the first few minutes or the sharp new jacket you intend to wear makes you unbearably warm, you'll want to rethink them.

Time yourself

As you do your trial run, actively monitor the time and take notes. Check the clock when you begin. Try to maintain the pace you expect to keep during your final delivery. Jot down the times of key points or transitions as you mock-present your content. Note the time when you finish.

If you'll be inviting interaction, prompting discussion, or answering questions, make assumptions about or set parameters for how much additional time to allow. How does the timing of your trial run plus these estimated additions compare to the allotted time for your presentation? Do you need to make adjustments?

In the instance when you have a fixed amount of time to present—a 10-minute slot on the meeting agenda or a 45-minute keynote presentation—take specific steps to ensure you stay on track. Create a timing sheet so you know exactly how long to spend on each section. Have this available to refer to when you present so you know whether you should pick up the pace to remain on schedule or slow down to fill the allotted time (unless finishing early is a viable option).

You can also build **buffers** into your content. These are places where you can spend additional time if you find you are getting through your material faster than anticipated or move through swiftly if you are running behind. One type of buffer is break slides between sections (following the previously mentioned navigation scheme). Use these to recap what you’ve gone through and set up what comes next in a more expansive or condensed way, depending on how you’re doing on time. Another candidate would be a dedicated point (or several over the course of your presentation) to invite audience interaction or input, such as Q&A. Again, this gives you the flexibility to spend more time if you have it or less if you are running behind.

Be precise with your words

The dry run is a great time to get specific about your word choice and phrasing, both to accurately make your intended points and to do so in ways that serve others. I attended a conference once where two speakers presented consecutively. I was impressed by one and offended by the other (so much so that I wrote down the notable quotes from the better presenter that I’ll share with you here). It struck me that the primary difference came down to their respective word choices for framing.

The superb speaker accounted for audience diversity, honored experience, and established credibility:

“If you aren’t familiar, I’ll give you a quick tour; if you are, bear with me for a minute.”

“You’ve seen this before, but I’m going to use it to...”

“I don’t have evidence for this, but I suspect...”

This was in stark contrast to the subpar speaker, who introduced things I’d seen before as if they were brand new and then proceeded to discuss another concept that was totally unfamiliar to me as if it was commonly known. Did he mean to offend? Not likely, but it felt like he didn’t bother to take his audience—me—into account, which made me less inclined to want to listen to him. Choose your words carefully, and use your dry run and other audible practice to form them.

Focus on you when you face time constraints

When we run up against a deadline, it’s easy to think that time will be best spent perfecting our content. But in reality, you will often be better served by setting your materials aside, letting them remain as they are, and concentrating on you and your delivery of the content. Employ the strategies we’ve examined throughout this chapter. Practice out loud. Get to know your materials well, and in particular, how you’ll transition between topics, sections, and slides. Plan a strong beginning and end. Get feedback ahead of time and integrate learnings. Do a dry run to prepare for how you’ll present and keep things on schedule.

Don’t you wish you attended more meetings and presentations where people did all of this?

In this chapter, we've explored a number of specific strategies that help us get to better know and be able to effectively talk through our materials. This thoughtful preparation in itself will build your self-assurance. *Everything* that we've covered up to this point will help you feel positively positioned as a presenter: getting to know your audience and crafting your message in a way that will work for them, developing story and building materials that will illustrate it effectively, and thoughtfully honing your content and delivery through practice.

Still, there is more that you can do to not only feel prepared but also demonstrate your ability to present with prowess. In the next chapter, we'll focus on techniques you can use as a presenter to feel and exude confidence.

Before we do that, let's revisit the case study we've been working on so I can share some of the specific tactics I employed to refine my content and delivery.

Refine through practice: TRIX case study

With my slide deck mostly done, I turn attention to myself as I prepare for the upcoming client meeting with Nosh. I've been deep in this project for so long that I know the details extremely well. That's good, but it can also be a little dangerous; this makes it easy to get caught up in the minutiae. I've built slide content that will hopefully stop me from doing this, but rehearsing what I intend to say is also critical.

I need to simply start talking in order to find my words and smoothly connect ideas and topics. I begin by putting my presentation deck in slide sorter view. Then I go through it—saying aloud the primary points I want to make on each slide and connecting it verbally to the next.



FIGURE 9.1 Slide sorter view

I realize a few things as I do this. First, there are a number of specifics I want to draw people's attention to in the story of TRIX trail mix over time (slide 4). Rather than a single static graph, this will be easier to do if I build it, using multiple views to highlight select data. This will facilitate things for me, since the slide progression itself will prompt me on the given points I want to illustrate. It will also help others, making it clear where they're meant to look as I'm speaking.

I identify a couple areas where additional slides will help me more smoothly transition between topics as well. On the "5 simple ingredients" slide (slide 5 in Figure 9.1), I found myself listing critical points about the importance of macadamia nuts and their recent price increase. I will draw more awareness to these topics by incorporating a separate slide for each. This will also allow me to reinforce my points since it means I'll be able to emphasize a single takeaway with each slide title and then support it with the slide content.

I also need to add a slide to introduce the product package testing before I share the results of the test (the latter is shown on slide 7 within Figure 9.1). This seems obvious now, but it wasn't until I talked through my slides in this view that I realized it. I note a few other places to build in transitional content and progressions that will help me better explain my graphs and highlight important data points. After making these modifications, I exit slide sorter view and talk through my deck one slide at a time.

At this juncture, it becomes clear that I overengineered the animation on my line graph. I thought it would be cool to have the TRIX line appear year by year. But this is far too much clicking when I go through the slide! I'll still build the graph, but it will better support my words if I bring the data in as segments of the line (instead of individual data points). Similarly, rather than introduce each of the three competitor lines one at a time, I'll layer them all on simultaneously. This will reflect how I plan to talk through the content and my overarching storyline.

The top of Figure 9.2 shows my original progression. Each black circle represents a click to make the given element appear. The first click introduced the graph title and axes labels and titles. Then I built the dark blue TRIX line one year at a time. I layered on each competitor (gray lines) one by one and then the other TRIX products one at a time. In all, this amounted to 17 clicks!

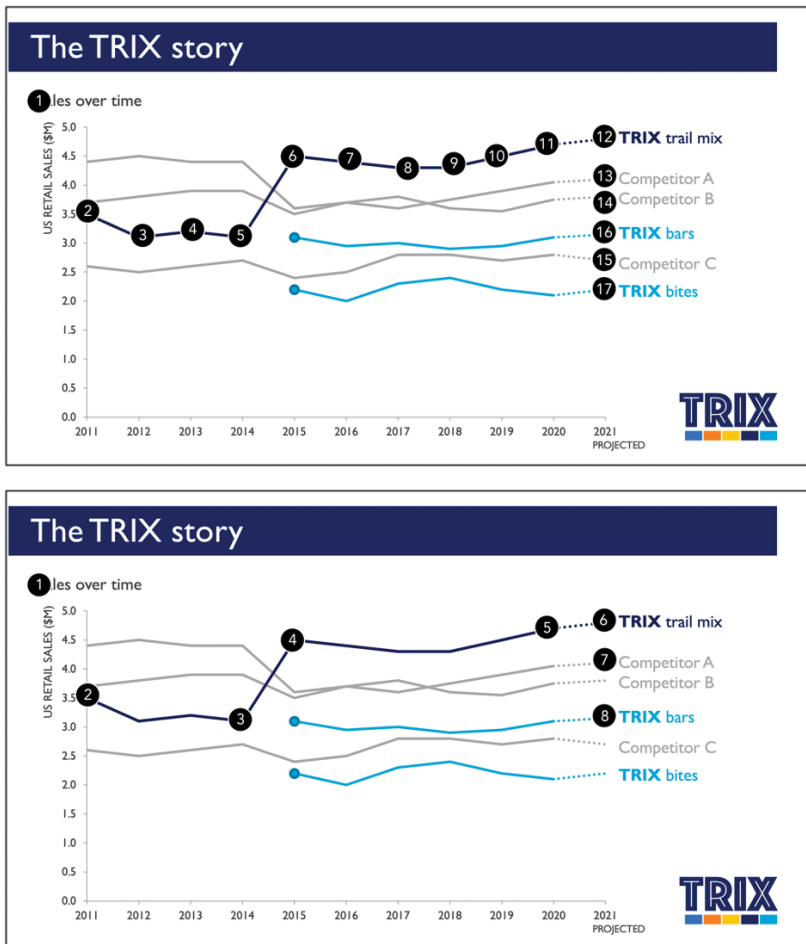


FIGURE 9.2 Scaling back from 17 to 8 clicks to build the graph progression

The bottom of Figure 9.2 shows my modified approach. I reduced the animation from 17 to 8 clicks and now have a progression that will both better guide and reinforce my talking points.

I talk through my slides on a few more occasions. I also look for opportunities to run through segments of content without my slides in front of me. I continue to make tweaks to my content and refine my delivery as I do so.

Part of what I plan through all this practice is how I'll start and end my presentation. I already have the perfect way to begin. I remind myself of that pithy and memorable phrase I formed in Chapter 6 for my presentation title: "The magic is in the macadamia nuts." I'll kick things off with this key message and launch from there into the story of TRIX, the issues faced, the tests we ran, what we learned, and our recommendation.

Thinking ahead to the ending, my goal is to drive an informed discussion among the client group. I've designed a slide with three clear options for consideration. I will use that to guide discussion and then repeat my title slide at the end, sending people off ready to act.

At this juncture, I reach out to some friendly folks at Nosh and schedule time to run them through my plans and get input. I start with Matt, Vanessa's chief of staff (you may recall that Vanessa is Head of Product for the product line that includes TRIX trail mix and is the one who commissioned this work). When we started this project, Matt had recently joined Nosh. Now that some time has passed, he has a better understanding of Vanessa's preferences and can help me make sure I address those. I'll also check with him to see if there are others it makes sense to meet with ahead of time.

I'll keep that conversation at a higher level and do my full dry run separately on my own, with an eye on the clock so that I get through my content in a reasonable amount of time.

It also occurs to me: we got early sign off on our general methodology from Abbey and Simon, the sensory analysts from Nosh's R&D team. Now would be a good time to sync with them again and run through the full analysis. This will be excellent practice for me in the event I have to get into any of these points during the main client meeting (in particular, if exacting divisional CFO Jack is in attendance). As an added benefit, having their support going into the final client meeting will help boost everyone else's confidence in our work.

Speaking of confidence, it's time to turn our attention there.



build your confidence

Let's kick off this chapter with a quick thought exercise. In a moment, I'm going to ask you to close your eyes. You'll take three deep breaths—in through your nose and out through your mouth. Then I want you to imagine that you have just given the most important presentation of your career, and it went fantastically well. Your audience was engaged. You changed their minds. They listened attentively, appreciated your perspective, and are now ready to act based on what you've shared. They applauded. People congratulated you afterwards on a job well done.

Go ahead: close your eyes, breathe, and envision the scene.

What does that success *feel* like? How does it show on your face and in your body? How does it express itself in your mind? Take a moment to identify several adjectives you would like others to use to describe you during that stellar presentation. When I do this activity, my list includes traits like comfortable, capable, self-assured, engaging, and poised. Keep your selected attributes in mind; we'll refer back to them soon.

Knowing your content is one thing, but commanding the attention of a room and creating the scenario you just imagined in reality is another. In this chapter, we'll explore strategies that will help you build your confidence to present

powerfully. To start, I'll ask you to record yourself and assess your skills today. From there, we'll dive into ways to establish presence through how you move and speak. We'll discuss techniques to calm nerves and steps to take to feel prepared. All of this together will build your confidence—and your capability—to deliver a knockout presentation.

Record yourself: watch and listen

Recording oneself is the single most uncomfortable—yet mighty—way of improving how you present. When you watch and listen to yourself, you can honestly evaluate your current ability as a presenter and identify specific improvements to make. This is an imperative step toward looking like you know what you're doing when you're in front of people.

When I worked at Google and was preparing for my first training sessions on data visualization, I took part in a train-the-trainer program, together with other soon-to-be-teaching colleagues. At one point in this course, we were recorded while presenting. We were asked to select a presentation and use it to present approximately five minutes of content. The directive was to pick something we knew well so we'd focus less on what we were saying and more on the delivery. I felt confident about the slide I had prepped. My excitement was only slightly marred by a few nerves when I stepped in front of the camera.

After everyone had a turn, we viewed the recordings together, each person first making observations about themselves and then entertaining points of feedback from the group. When I watched my recording, there was one thing that stood out to me more than anything else: I was wearing shoes with heels, as I often do when I present, and was shifting awkwardly from front to back on my feet. This caused my entire body to sway. If someone had given me the feedback, "Try planting your feet while talking—it's distracting when you shift back and forth," it would have been easy for me to disregard. But seeing myself do it made me recognize a couple things. First, the resulting body sway was horribly distracting. I also realized with embarrassment that I had probably been doing

that *every time I had been in front of an audience* up to that point! Once I became aware of my bad habit, I curbed it immediately.

The lesson: record yourself. You'll see things you're doing and hear things you're saying that you'll want to adjust. Let's talk about exactly how to do this.

Set yourself up and record

Start by determining what you will present. It doesn't have to be long—and shouldn't be, given the number of times I'm going to suggest you review it. Around five minutes of presenting is generally enough time to make a good assessment. Choose something that you know well and are able to comfortably talk through for that duration. You might pick a slide or two from a recent presentation, discuss your favorite pastime and why you like it, or introduce yourself (Chapter 11 explores the art of the introduction; if you don't have a topic handy to record, turn your attention there and then come back to this). Irrespective of the subject, approach it as though you are presenting it formally in a meeting or presentation setting. I recommend doing this once for practice and then a second time while recording.

Record both audio and video. When you do so, think ahead to how you'll ultimately present. If you're preparing for a virtual session or a meeting where you'll be seated at a table, record yourself seated while talking through your slides. If you'll be standing when you present, set up your camera so you can do this for the recording, too. Emulate the environment to see how you'll fare in the anticipated setting. Pretend the camera is your audience, and speak to it as you would to them.

Today's technology makes recording easy

It's funny to think back to the Google scenario. We used a camcorder on a tripod with a person at the helm to film. My performance was recorded onto a VHS tape that was subsequently put into a VCR connected to a television to view. Today, that process is much simpler: smart phones, computers with built-in cameras, and technology like Zoom make it fast and easy for anyone to record themselves and watch it back. Take advantage of this ease and use it to improve the way you communicate!

After recording yourself, I suggest watching it several times, concentrating your assessment on different aspects of your presentation. I'll walk you through three rounds of review and what to look and listen for in each.

Review #1: overcome the awkwardness

If you've ever listened to your recorded voice played back before, you've perhaps experienced the reaction, "I don't sound like that!" It's true: you don't sound like that to yourself because you're used to hearing your voice from the perspective of the one speaking rather than the person listening. It's similarly uncomfortable to see yourself present for the first time and get hung up on something that comes across differently than you expected.

This first review is simply to recognize this common reaction and get over preconceived notions about how you look and sound. Let this initial assessment be about getting used to seeing and hearing yourself present and overcoming any awkwardness you feel when doing so. This will make it easier to more critically and helpfully evaluate the recording when you watch it again. With that reaction out of the way, you can pay close attention to the details and identify actionable improvements to make.

Review #2: watch yourself

Make your second viewing of the recording all about watching yourself. For this, I suggest muting the volume and focusing entirely on how you look and move. Take notes as you watch. What stands out to you? Look both for the details that are working well and also anything distracting or otherwise not ideal.

You'll likely have some obvious observations arise as you watch yourself. If you need a starting point, below are some specifics to pay attention to and related questions to consider.

- **Posture:** Are you standing or sitting up straight? Do you seem too loose or stiff?
- **Eyes:** Where are you looking? Are you blinking normally?
- **Facial expression:** Are you smiling, frowning, or making other notable faces?
- **Hands:** Where are they, and how are you using them?
- **Other body movement:** Are you doing anything too much or too little?

Take special note of whatever strikes you as awkward or comes across as uncomfortable or undesirable in other ways.

Recording to learn and get feedback as a new hire

In 2019, when data storytellers Mike Cisneros and Alex Velez joined the *storytelling with data* team (pre-pandemic, before virtual meetings were the norm), their top priority was to learn and get comfortable and confident delivering our popular half-day workshop. With each of us living in different cities and different time zones, we had to come up with creative ways to make it happen. Each week, they would read, study, and practice a given lesson from the workshop. At the end of the week, they'd record themselves talking through it and send the recording to me. This had dual benefits: they were able to watch the videos to critique and

improve their own delivery, and I would also review, see progress, and offer input.

This strategy worked extremely well for onboarding new hires in our non-colocated environment. It also formed a great habit and ease for recording to refine. This is a practice that the rest of the team and I regularly employ. Given the shift toward virtual offices, video recording is a great way to learn and get feedback—both for new hires and for the rest of the team!

Review #3: listen to yourself

Now that you have a sense of how you look when you're presenting, it's time to pay attention to how you sound. Your voice is a powerful communication tool—one to which people generally don't pay sufficient attention. Turn off or minimize the video in this final review and listen to the audio. What do you notice?

Take notes like you did when you watched yourself. Below, I've outlined several considerations to be aware of in particular.

- **Filler words:** Are you saying anything unnecessary (um, like, etc.)?
- **Repeated words:** Are you overusing any specific words or phrases?
- **Pace of speech:** Are you speaking too quickly or slowly? Does the tempo vary?
- **Pauses:** Do you integrate any pauses? Do they seem like the right length?
- **Volume:** Are you too loud or soft? Does your volume fluctuate appropriately?
- **Pitch:** Does it range sufficiently, or do you sound monotone or singsongy?

Like you did when you watched yourself, pay attention both to the aspects of your speech that are working well and anything that stands out to you in a negative way.

Evaluate yourself: pull your observations together

You've watched and listened to yourself present. Reflect back on the adjectives I asked you to identify at the beginning of this chapter. What differences exist between who you'd like to be when you present and your current ways of doing so?

Don't be disappointed by any gaps you identify. Reframe how you think about them: these are opportunities! This is the fun part—you get to undertake specific actions to improve. I will reveal the tactics that my team and I employ to great effect. I am a strong believer that everyone can become increasingly adept when it comes to how they communicate with others. Now is your chance.

Watch and learn from others

One way to improve how you communicate is to learn from others: actively listen and watch others present. Pay close attention to mannerisms and delivery. What do they do well that you could emulate? What less-than-ideal behaviors do you observe that you'll want to steer clear of in your own delivery? How might you channel the techniques you see work well for others in a way that feels authentic to you?

To share your learnings from this process—and benefit from others' evaluations of various speakers—check out the SWD community exercise “learn from TED.” Upon submitting your own solution, you'll be able to see those that peers have put forth (community.storytellingwithdata.com/exercises/learn-from-ted).

Look like someone people want to watch

When you present, I recommend trying to look like someone others are going to want to look at and pay attention to. Please don't misconstrue this to mean anything about physical beauty or attractiveness. I'm referring to the way you portray yourself through your body language: how you carry yourself and how you move. If you do this in a manner that looks comfortable and self-assured, it helps to put your audience at ease and have them perceive you as confident and capable, too.

Stand up, maintain good posture, move with intention, make eye contact, and do other proactive things to feel (and thus look) your best. Let's talk more about each of these.

Stand up

One thing I advocate whenever possible—and I think it's workable more often than people take advantage of—is to stand up when presenting during a meeting. This move alone can get your audience's attention and keep them engaged for longer because it's out of the norm. This seemingly minor modification makes an incredible difference. As I reflect back on my own path speaking in front of others, the simple change from seated to standing marked an interesting turning point in my own confidence and command as a presenter.

As part of the train-the-trainer program I mentioned earlier that I undertook while working at Google, one of the instructors, Niamh, attended my class to observe and offer feedback. I was delivering a two-hour training session on the topic of data visualization. We were in a room with a large conference table in the middle of it. My slides were projected onto a big screen at one end. I sat at the head of the table on the other side.

After the session, I got one of the best pieces of advice I've received in my career: stand up. Niamh said that during the training, she'd been constantly looking back and forth between me and the slides. The images on the slides

were critical to illustrate the concepts I was teaching. But I—at the opposite end of the table—was so animated that she couldn't help but watch me. Given the current arrangement, the slides and I were competing against each other for attention. But the simple change of me standing up and moving to the front of the room meant we would work in concert.

Modify your position to shift the energy

Consider your physical positioning in the space as it relates to others. I've shared my advice to stand up; if everyone else is seated and you are standing, this gives you an air of authority over your audience that can be useful. When this is not desired, change it up. In a workshop where I've been standing to teach and want to pivot into casual discussion, I will pull up a chair and physically sit down. This action brings me level with participants, modifying the vibe of the situation. Alternatively, in a meeting where everyone is seated and you want to shift things in some way, standing up is a great way to garner attention. We'll explore this idea further and discuss some additional advantages standing up affords in Chapter 12.

Maintain good posture

Whether seated or standing, be aware of your posture.

Good posture maintains the natural curve of your spine. Benefits to maintaining good posture include less muscle strain, increased energy levels, better balance, easier coordination among body parts, expanded lung capacity, and improved self-confidence, to name a few. Maintaining good posture when presenting will help boost your stamina. It's also more pleasant for your audience to look at you when you exhibit the best posture that your body and environment allows.

If you are unable to stand while presenting, to achieve a proper seated position, start with your butt touching the back of your chair. Slouch forward and then draw yourself up, accentuating the curve of your back as far as possible. Release slightly, about ten degrees.

When standing, stand tall! Keep your head level and in line with your body (chin tucked slightly, not pushed forward). This means your ears will line up with the middle of your shoulders. Speaking of shoulders, they should be relaxed, down, and back—don't hunch forward. Pull in your abdomen. Place your feet shoulder-width apart, with knees slightly bent (don't lock them!) and your weight mostly on the balls of your feet. To test your standing posture, position yourself with your back to a wall, with your shoulders and butt touching it. The back of your head should lightly touch the wall.

Your body language says things, too

Establishing good posture is a great first step for the non-verbal communication that happens through your body language. When you stand up straight with your shoulders back, you exude confidence. There are numerous other signals people read from different postures, both good and bad. It is useful to understand these common interpretations because much of our body language happens subconsciously—until we become aware of and take steps to intentionally harness it.

On the negative side, putting your hands in your pockets can be interpreted as insecurity, shyness, or meekness. Crossing your arms in front of your body creates a barrier between you and others, often interpreted as a signal of disagreement, defensiveness, or anxiety. While leaning away typically indicates feelings of dislike or negativity, leaning in or toward others is a sign that you are interested and engaged.

We'll revisit and expand on some of these ideas as they relate to our audience in Chapter 12. In the same way they watch our body language as we present, there are important cues we can read from theirs in the meeting or presentation, too.

Now that we've got the sitting and standing down, let's shift to moving.

Move with intention

When you watched the recording of yourself presenting, you perhaps noticed movements you were making without realizing it. Movement itself isn't a bad thing—it helps the feeling and flow of a presentation—when it is done with intent. This is not the distracting rocking-back-and-forth motion that I described in my Google story; it's purposefully taking a step forward and throwing your hands in the air to signal something BIG (for example).

On the topic of hands, knowing what to do with them is sometimes a challenge. Did you notice anything about yours when you reviewed your recording? If not, you were probably using them well. Conversely, you may have noted an overuse of hand movement, or if you observed any stiffness to your delivery, it could be that you didn't use them enough.

When others are watching you, use **hand motion** to indicate when you'd like them to look at your slides by motioning toward the screen (this is particularly useful if you are standing in a different part of the room than where your slides are displayed, which we'll discuss momentarily). In a similar manner, you can use your hands to cue *who* to look at. If I'm going to pull Alicia into the conversation, I will gesture toward her, prompting others to look in her direction. I can also signal an invitation with my hands. When I ask my audience for input or to discuss, I open my arms out to them as I invite interaction and leave them

there during the ensuing pause until the first person speaks up. Consider how to use hand motion to your advantage through intentional movements and when you will be better off allowing them to hang naturally so they don't distract.

No need to draw attention to your clicker

When using a clicker to advance slides, invest in one that has good range (I use the Logitech Spotlight Presentation Remote). This means you can stand anywhere in the room and progress through slides with ease. You do not have to physically hold it out, pointing it at your computer to advance the presentation. Instead, think of the clicker as an extension of your hand, letting it fall to your side or using it purposefully to get attention or reinforce your content.

You can also use your hands—and the rest of your body—to emphasize content by making **spatial associations**. I'll often use the following tactic when I'm referring to something *before* and then *after* a given change. Assuming I'm facing others from the front of the room, for *before*, I'll motion my hands and physically turn my body to my right. Those facing me will see this at their left, now associating the before state with left. Then, to describe *after*, I'll move my hands to my left (my audience's right) and direct my body in that direction. In this manner, I've created a physical association in the room (you can also envision how I might do this in a virtual setting with my hands front and center, moving them from right to left). Then, when I refer back to the before state verbally, I can indicate it physically by gesturing in that direction, helping reinforce it.

While I used *before* and *after* in the preceding explanation, this strategy can be applied generally to highlight a distinction between one state and another. Imagine how I could even extend this to a multi-state process from start to finish,

where I begin on my right and physically take steps leftward as I verbalize the progression from one state to another until the end. Doing that across the front of a room creates spatial associations for my audience, which I can reference later to bring specific content or points of discussion back to my mind in potentially helpful ways.

When utilizing this technique, do it sparingly to avoid confusion. I mentioned this, but also be aware of how you are positioned relative to those watching you. In Western cultures, the natural flow for a process is from left to right; if I'm facing others, it makes sense for me to move from my right to my left to create an instinctive progression from the perspective of my audience.

Beyond using the physical space to associate with content and reinforce concepts, think about how you can best **move around the area** in which you present. Will it be helpful for others to see you and your slides simultaneously? If so, position yourself where this is possible. When presenting to a full room, you may walk from one side of the front of the room to the other, so that irrespective of where people are sitting, they feel equally addressed. In other cases, it might make sense to spend time walking to and presenting from different parts of the room. When I teach a workshop, I spend time teaching from the back of the room and from the sides of the room (when it doesn't compete with my projected materials) in addition to the front. If you aren't used to doing this, it feels uncomfortable at first. Like most things, continued practice can help you understand whether and when it will work and do it with increasing ease.

Make use of the space in virtual presentations

It probably won't make sense to walk around the room when you're presenting virtually, but you can still make use of the strategies we've discussed by modifying them for the virtual setting. Practice ahead of time while watching yourself through the camera. Take advantage of this to gain a thorough understanding of how much of your body others will see and how much space you have to each side and in front of you.

It is also useful to see yourself while you're presenting as long as you can do so in ways that don't distract you from looking primarily at the camera. For instance, when presenting virtually I have an external camera mounted directly above my computer screen. My camera has a built-in display that I position next to the lens, allowing me to see myself out of the corner of my eye while looking at the lens and presenting. This is helpful if I want to use my hands to emphasize something and make sure they are within the shot. The physical area in which I move is more constrained than in person, but I can still utilize it to my advantage.

Make eye contact

A simple way to engage your audience is to look them in the eyes. This is one aspect of presenting that is actually easier in a virtual environment because I am able to look my entire audience in the eyes (from their perspective) simultaneously when I focus directly on my camera. This same feat isn't possible in person if I'm presenting to more than a single individual! When presenting to multiple people or addressing a room, change where you are looking enough in order for everyone to feel included (and not ignored) but not so often or rapidly that it feels haphazard or jarring. This generally means making a statement or two with your attention directed toward one person or area in the room, then changing where you're looking. In a large room, you may simply

face part of the room (without making specific eye contact or without holding it long enough for any individual to feel singled out). In a smaller setting, you will make eye contact with individuals.

If what I've just described ignites any feelings of discomfort, get comfortable by practicing. Stand up and address the room you're in now. This might mean making a statement to a chair, then a window, then a door. Also practice while watching yourself in the mirror. The goal is simply to look comfortable and natural. Also don't forget to blink!

What does your face say?

Think of your facial expression as a window into what you are thinking and how you are feeling. Are you happy to be there and passionate about your topic? Do you want to connect with and engage your audience? If so, smile! Or are you pensive, reflecting on a question someone just posed to you and requiring a moment to gather your thoughts? Look the part: you might bring a hand to your face, look up or to the side (which indicates thinking), or perhaps furrow your brow. Most of this will come naturally if you are genuinely engaged and interested in the subject and discussion.

If you're presenting on stage in a large group or have been diminished to a flat screen in the virtual environment, exaggerate your expressions a bit to ensure they are visible. This feels a little awkward at first, but it becomes easier with practice. Being animated in these scenarios where you've been reduced in size or dimension from the perspective of your audience will help ensure you don't come across as apathetic. Facial expression is especially important when presenting virtually since people typically see little else.

Do proactive things to feel your best

We've talked about a number of aspects you can pay attention to and practice that will help you establish good physical presence when you communicate. Beyond these specifics, think about what you can do generally that will make you feel good in your body and ready to present. Get enough sleep. Wear clothes that make you feel self-assured. Do things that will help you be the best version of yourself. When you feel confident, it is easier to get others to be confident in you, too.

Amp up your natural tendencies

Look closely at yourself and your innate ways, then actively fold the best parts of that into how you present. The next time you're chatting with a friend about something you're passionate about—sports, music, politics—take note of what you do. Be aware of how you position your body and your hands. Are you leaning in, or are your shoulders back? Does anything happen with the volume or pace of your speech? Ask a trusted friend to identify the mannerisms that make you shine. Think about how to integrate some of these characteristics into how you present when discussing other topics, too. Captivate others by exuding interest in your topic in a way that works for you (and engages them!).

Sound like someone people want to listen to

There is immense power in how you use your voice when presenting. How you speak makes the difference between keeping someone's attention and losing it. This is true in terms of what you say but also—and just as important—how you say it. Do you sound like someone people want to listen to?

Eliminate filler words

Start by identifying and removing any unnecessary repeated sounds, words, or phrases from your verbal communications. You likely noted some filler words when you listened to yourself present. These are the “ums,” “ahs,” and “you knows” that make us sound unprepared, uncertain, or lacking confidence. They distract, making it difficult to succinctly establish your point or clearly get your message across.

In addition to flagging the unnecessary sounds you make, work to understand in what instances you do so. This is key to curbing the bad habit. A common situation where filler words creep in is when you are thinking of a word that you want to use. To counter that, get comfortable with silence. Preceding your next word with “ummmmmmmmm...” comes across like you don’t know what you’re talking about, whereas pausing and then simply saying the appropriate word once your mind lands on it (even if it takes a couple seconds) sounds thoughtful and composed.

Read what you say to improve how you speak

Transcribing or reading the transcription of your verbal communication is an eye-opening experience that can help you quickly identify poor speaking habits. Revisit the recording I advised you to make earlier in the chapter. Listen again and write down what you say. Note the things that you’re taking down repeatedly—these are likely superfluous sounds, words, or phrases.

If you don’t have the patience for that, technology can help. The Descript Audio Editor will analyze audio against common filler words and give you a frequency count. My team and I learned about this through editing the *storytelling with data* podcast and started using it proactively with our workshop and presentation recordings to identify our verbal crutches and work to avoid them.

After eliminating unnecessary sounds, words, and phrases, you can continue to get more sophisticated when it comes to how you use your voice.

A strong voice starts with good breathing

You may be nervous, but you don't need to let a shaky voice divulge that to others! The first step to ensure vigor and volume in your voice is to make sure you are breathing well. We've discussed posture as it relates to how you sit and stand. Good carriage is key for your breathing—and thus your voice—too.

When you sit erect or stand tall, there is space for your lungs to expand. Breathe deeply: when your lungs have air, it enables you to have a loud and clear resonance. When you don't breathe frequently or deeply enough, it will lead to problems like a quivering voice.

Protect your voice!

Once, in the middle of a hectic business trip in Australia, I lost my voice entirely. It happened after several packed days of workshops and speaking appearances (including a pivotal one without a microphone where I had to project my voice, unaided, to a large audience). This was a wake up call to me on how critical my voice is to my work—and that I had better protect it. After diagnosing the issue as simply overuse with an otolaryngologist, I learned how to take better preemptive care: stay hydrated, avoid acidic foods, and always have a microphone available to reduce vocal strain when presenting.

Speaking without enough breath can also lead to something called **vocal fry**. This happens when insufficient air is pushed through the vocal chords—they can't rub together as they are meant to, which creates a raspy, creaky, or fried

sound. If you notice that you sound different or run out of voice at the end of a long sentence, this is likely what's happening. To counter it, breathe deeply and use shorter sentences. Varying your vocal cadence also helps.

Vocal cadence: variety is key

Vocal cadence describes the rhythm or modulation of speech. I've also heard this described as the *texture* of voice. I like this term because it implies that there's something interesting and varied about it; if there's texture, it isn't flat or monotonous.

You possibly made observations related to these aspects of how you sound when you listened to the recording of yourself. After becoming aware of your natural cadence when presenting, think about why, when, and how you might alter it. Variety in pace, volume, and pitch make you sound more interesting and more interested in what you're saying.

Let's first consider the **pace** at which you speak. Increasing your speed is a way to express excitement about something. Alternatively, when reaching an important point, you could *slow down* to fully articulate and emphasize each word and allow time for the idea to sink in. Related to allowing time, pauses play a vital role in the rhythm of speech as well. You can pause as a way to get attention ahead of saying something crucial or after a statement to let the point you just made register fully. Pauses let you punctuate your spoken words. They also provide critical time for you to breathe deeply—something important for the next aspect we'll discuss.

You can also alter **volume** in interesting ways. At times, it might make sense to GET LOUD TO MAKE A POINT. Did it sound like I raised my voice just then? (Related note: be aware that text in all caps reads like you are yelling!) In other instances, I may speak *softly* or even whisper. Employed smartly, this can really get people's attention since they have to work harder to listen. This is a useful trick to get everyone to tune in before you say something important. (Use caution when employing this tactic, however; it's best to whisper only if you have a microphone amplifying it so everyone is still able to hear.)

Pitch is another component of your voice that you can vary. This is the relative lowness or highness. If you recall the vocal fry that I mentioned previously, this happens most commonly when speaking at the lower end of your vocal range; if you observe it happening, try adjusting your pitch to the middle of your range. Varying your pitch is what will keep you from sounding monotone. Use it to express excitement (higher pitch) or underscore the feelings you'd like to conjure in your audience. For example, when addressing something sad or serious, you may want to lower your pitch.

When finding your presenting voice and modifying your pace, volume, and pitch, be careful not to overdo it. The goal is to sound natural, authentic, and genuinely interested in what you are communicating.

Sound like you care

If you don't care what you're talking about—you've not found the passion or the interest—no one else is going to care about it, either. Not everything is naturally fascinating. But if you sound blasé about your topic, it will be difficult to elicit a positive response from others. Simply put, when we speak in a way that makes us appear and sound excited about our topic, we get our audience's attention in a totally different manner. Think back to the *kākāpō* anecdote I mentioned at the onset of Chapter 9: because the presenter was passionate about the topic at hand, I cared more than I otherwise would have. That is profound.

One way you can tap into aspects of this has to do with how you use your body when you communicate. Voice follows body. If my shoulders are hunched over and I'm looking at my feet—my voice sounds different. I don't exude confidence or feel confident. Try it. Assume the posture I've described. Look at the floor and say, "The *kākāpō* is critically endangered." Next, let's contrast this with some different body language. Stand up tall and put your shoulders back. Raise your hands in front of your body and use them for emphasis as you repeat the sentence: "The *kākāpō* is critically endangered." I sound totally different as a result of how I position my body; I'll bet you do, too. Consider how to do this when you present.

As a related aside: being aware of how you move and how you sound and having the wherewithal to adjust in the moment requires some free mindshare. This is one of the reasons I suggest that you spend so much time planning and practicing to get comfortable with your presentation content. If your whole brain is devoted to remembering what comes next, it's impossible to also think about how you look and sound. When you know your content well, it leaves space to pay attention to and play with these other aspects of how you communicate.

Before you present, there are a few final things I suggest doing to boost your confidence. Let's shift our conversation to these.

Actively prepare

One way to help get over any nerves you experience leading up to your important meeting or presentation is to take proactive steps to be fully prepared for what you will face when you present. This makes it easier to feel calm and collected.

Gather your equipment

Be equipped, and you will feel equipped! To achieve this, I'm an advocate of assembling a presenter pack. When you have your supplies packed and ready to go, you're less likely to forget something important. The specific contents will vary somewhat depending on your needs and will change over time as you learn what you must have and what you can safely omit. Figure 10.1 shows a presenter pack I assembled recently for the new hires on my team who will be traveling to facilitate workshops.



FIGURE 10.1 Presenter pack with select contents

My personal presenter pack typically includes:

- My favorite clicker to advance slides (with charging cable or back-up batteries)
- Laptop charger and HDMI adapter
- A thumb drive that I load my slide deck on ahead of time (just in case)
- Branded pens (to give to anyone who needs one)
- Sharpie markers (in the event I want to draw something for everyone to see)
- Voice and breath accoutrements (throat tea, lozenges, mints)
- Sticky notes (I never go anywhere without them)
- Blue Painter's Tape (useful for taping up signs, taping down cords, and more)
- Business cards and stickers (to remind people where to keep learning)
- A handy zipped case to hold it all

In addition to gathering my supplies, I'll also plan time to visit the space in which I'll present.

Visit the space

If it is possible, visit the room where you'll present ahead of time. This is an excellent way to identify potential problems and resolve them before they materialize. Also, the simple act of being in and familiarizing yourself with the space makes it less intimidating.

Plan dedicated time in the conference room if it's a meeting in your office, or schedule a tech check in advance of offsite presentations if possible. This gives you the opportunity to practice setting up your computer, running through your slides, and working out any related matters.

As part of this, you'll want to understand where and how both you and your audience will see your presentation. This will help you make final preparations in order for things to go smoothly. In some cases, you may have your laptop directly in front of you or otherwise in your line of sight with presenter mode enabled so you are able to see what slide comes next and your speaker notes. In other instances, you might have a confidence monitor at the foot of the stage you're standing on that shows the current slide so you can glance at it without turning your back to people. With this knowledge in hand, plan whether and how you'll move about the area.

This is also a great time to rehearse how you'll use your voice—and any technology you'll employ to amplify it. Get familiar with the microphone if you'll be using one. Learn how to turn it on and off and mute it. If it clips on your clothing, take note of how and whether to make adjustments to your planned attire.

More prepared means easier to roll with the unexpected

Years ago, I presented a keynote address at a large conference in Austria where I wasn't able to visit the venue or test technology ahead of time. Had I done so, I would have learned in advance that there were no good options for attaching the clip-on microphone to my dress and chosen something different to wear. No such luck. Moments before I walked on stage, a savvy audio-visual tech was able to fasten the battery pack in a less-than-ideal location at the back neckline of my dress (I could feel the low ponytail I'd arranged my hair in resting on it!).

If I hadn't felt well prepared in other ways—I knew my content and was confident in my abilities—this might have thrown off everything. However, given the thoroughness of the rest of my planning, it was a minor inconvenience during an otherwise *ausgezeichnet* (that's German for awesome) event.

Run through all of your slides. You don't have to talk through each of them at this point, but you should view them all because this can highlight any final changes to make to your content. Take on the perspective of your audience as you do this. Move around the space to see how it will display for those in different parts of the room. For example, if you find some text is too small to be legible from the back or a color doesn't come across well on the projector, modify it.

When preparing for a virtual meeting, have a planning call if you haven't already. Do so from the same spot in your home or office where you'll ultimately present. Determine how to set up the space and use the technology for a smooth session.

Now that you know what it looks like, visualize yourself in the space presenting with aplomb. It is also useful to foresee what may not go entirely as intended.

Anticipate where things could go wrong

When you foresee how something might go differently than planned, you can devise an appropriate course of action to deal with it. This will help you respond to the unexpected more eloquently when it comes up in your meeting or presentation—which almost always happens at some point.

Nothing ever goes exactly as planned. Recall the anecdote I shared when my voice gave out earlier. To deal with it, I canceled my involvement in the non-obligatory events in my schedule to preserve my voice. I reached out to the upcoming essential one—a client training—to give them a heads up and brainstorm solutions. Thankfully, a resourceful attendee volunteered to bring their own microphone and speakers for me to use. I adjusted the content for more group work to reduce the amount I'd be talking. My patient participants that day listened to me basically whisper the workshop.

Over the many hundreds of times I've spoken to a room of people, it seems like most everything has gone wrong at some point: a key constraint wasn't disclosed ahead of time, my flight got canceled and I had to drive four hours overnight to get to the event (I was seven months pregnant and got a speeding ticket in that instance!), the AV guy was late to work and no one else knew how to run the finicky projector, critical handouts for 100 attendees weren't printed ahead of time as planned, the audience resisted the change I'd been asked to communicate, the power went out. This is merely a sampling of issues I've faced that run the gamut! Interestingly, these undesirable situations often have a way of inspiring creative solutions that can be leveraged in the future. As you anticipate what could go wrong when you present, spend special time thinking about how to react gracefully (an idea we'll revisit in Chapter 12). It may improve not only the given presentation but also others to come.

A stoic approach to put things in perspective

One sometimes useful angle to take when thinking about your upcoming meeting or presentation and feeling nervous or anxious is to anticipate the worst that could happen. We tend to exaggerate the stakes in our minds and put undue pressure on ourselves. Unless you're dealing with true life-and-death topics, a single failed communication—while not ideal—is a far cry from the end of the world.

Remind yourself of this reality by imagining things going awry. What is the absolute worst thing that is likely to happen as a result of this? Often, that worst thing isn't really so awful. Also, once you've thought about how bad things can get, you'll get increased satisfaction when they go better than that. This reframing helps reduce your stress, leaving you better able to perform and appreciate what you've done.

It is often helpful to involve others in the exercise of anticipating problems. You can even make a game out of it with colleagues, brainstorming possible issues and how to resolve them. Think of it like disaster training. What technology dilemmas could arise—for example, what if you can't get your slides to project or your clicker runs out of batteries in the middle of your delivery? What back-up plans should you put in place? What people problems may you encounter? Perhaps a critical supporter has a last-minute conflict and can't attend, a stakeholder gets unruly, or you face resistance you didn't expect. Brainstorm questions and practice answering them and redirecting conversations if this is warranted. Anticipating the breadth of scenarios you might face ahead of time will help you respond elegantly to whatever arises.

You've done it: you've built your confidence. It's nearly go time! Before we get there, we have a couple final things to consider—including a quick look at the case study we've been working through.

Build your confidence: TRIX case study

To continue to prepare for the upcoming client meeting, I record myself talking through a short section of slides from my planned presentation. I've recorded myself a number of times before, so I am able to quickly identify changes to make. I look relatively good when it comes to my posture and how I'm moving, but I note several opportunities to tighten my words.

My goal is to sound prepared and polished without coming across as scripted or overly rehearsed. I need to inspire confidence—both to help guide my immediate client group to a smart decision and, more generally, to help us book Nosh as an ongoing client.

My list of refinements includes:

- **Don't use my hands as much.** I have to tone this down slightly so my hands don't distract from what I'm saying, particularly when I make a key point.
- **Don't start sentences with "So...."** I seem to be using this pointless word when I move from one slide to the next. I'll practice talking aloud through my content to identify better ways to transition.
- **Eliminate "sort of" from my vocabulary.** This unnecessary phrase found its way into my seven-minute video 11 times! It makes me sound wishy-washy in instances where I should be direct and confident. Striking it entirely will be super beneficial.
- **Reduce my use of "right?" to end sentences.** I seem to be doing this to be conversational and get affirmation while presenting, but it's annoying and unnecessary.

I write the words "So...", "sort of," and "right?" on a sticky note, draw a red X through them, and stick it on my computer monitor where I will see it regularly in the days leading up to my presentation. I alert my closest colleagues to

flag these words and phrases and aim to strike any uses from my general daily conversations as well.

When I met recently with Matt at Nosh to review my plan for the presentation, we convened in the room where the final meeting will take place. I used that as an opportunity to practice presenting from my laptop and ran through my slides to confirm they look good. I also got a sense of the room and decided to stand when I present. This way, I can spend some time at the front with the slides and move around the room as makes sense during the meeting.

While at Nosh, I also checked in with sensory analysts Abbey and Simon and gathered some questions they had and some they expect others will raise during the meeting. I do some additional brainstorming with my team about what could go wrong and other queries that are likely to come up. I also ask them to role-play to practice answering and feel comfortable directing the conversation.

I assemble my presenter pack with my supplies. I am ready to present.

Before I get to my presentation, however, let's tackle one more chapter that is devoted entirely to *you*.



introduce yourself

You have surely introduced yourself before—perhaps during a job interview, when meeting the associate of a friend, at a networking event, or during the first few moments of a presentation.

But have you ever paused and given much thought to how you do so?

“Hi, my name is Cole, and I tell stories with data.” I have said those words, standing in front of unfamiliar faces in venues all over the world, literally thousands of times over the past decade. I’ve done that despite being an introvert and definitely not considering myself to be a naturally stand-in-front-of-people-and-speak-comfortably kind of person. This didn’t happen by accident; it evolved through careful planning and practice. Over the years, I’ve had the opportunity to help my team and clients craft their introductions as well. It is that same approach that I will share with you here.

It may strike you as odd to encounter an entire chapter devoted to this topic and to come across it so late in the process of planning, creating, and delivering your presentation. This is intentional. The way you introduce yourself—whether formally on a stage or in daily life—can have a profound impact on the way that others perceive you. It’s an opportunity to form a personal connection and establish rapport. Building on the last chapter, being able to talk *about yourself* eloquently will increase your confidence, too.

The targeted process of composing your introduction that I outline in the following pages will give you the opportunity to tap into a number of the strategies we've examined throughout this book. You'll need to actually undertake the activities as I lay them out in this chapter, so grab a pen and paper (and some sticky notes if you have them handy) and get ready to do some work. Even if you don't have an important meeting or presentation on the horizon, you can still actively apply lessons and hone skills that will help you when you do. Bonus: the output of this process will be a compelling introduction that will serve you well—in your presentations and beyond!

Plan the story of you—starting with *them*

In the same way that we discussed it in the context of presentation design, spending ample time up front planning your introduction is key. Rarely—in a business setting, at least—will you tell your full life story. Which parts of your background, the specific combination of experiences, and level of detail you share should be driven by each scenario and what you hope to accomplish. While you'll be able to pull from the work you do here for similar occasions, when the situation in which you need to introduce yourself changes appreciably, you'll want to revisit this process.

Before you spend time thinking about yourself, let's start by acknowledging those who will be on the receiving side of your introduction: your audience.

I'll pose many of the same questions I asked you to think about in Chapter 1 early in the planning process. Who is your audience? What motivates them? What drives them and the things they do—or don't do? What do they care about? What is at stake for them? You may find it helpful to review and complete the Big Idea worksheet from Chapter 2. If you're crafting your intro without a specific scenario and audience in mind, think generally about what you believe the people you'll be introducing yourself to will care about or be inspired by.

Identify key impressions

Contemplate the impressions you would like to make when you introduce yourself. How do you want others to perceive you? If someone were to describe you after you tell them about yourself, how would they do so—what words would they use? In thinking about this, don't focus on the reaction to what you say. Instead, target the perceptions that will be formed about you. Reflect on the qualities you want to ensure come across, the characteristics you want to demonstrate, and the feelings you want to evoke. You may recall that I asked you to do something similar at the onset of Chapter 10. In this instance, we're going to explore your desired attributes—and how to actively portray them—much more deeply.

Spend five minutes completing the following sentence in various ways: I would like to be described as _____. This will yield a list of adjectives, perhaps descriptors like confident, smart, or passionate. Five minutes is a long time for this simple exercise, and that is by design. It's to push you past the initial few words that come to mind and encourage you to think critically about the breadth of potential impressions that you would like to create among those to whom you introduce yourself. Consulting a thesaurus as part of this may be helpful.

Once you've made your list—and if it doesn't have at least ten adjectives, I suggest that you spend an additional minute or two—it's time to prioritize. From the adjectives you've assembled, identify the key impressions you absolutely must make on your audience. Aim for 3–5 attributes that are distinct from one another (if you have several similar ideas, group them together into a single category and pick the word or combination of words that best describes it). Hold onto this shortened list of key perceptions you'd like to create; it's going to assist what we do next.

Demonstrate through action

How can you create the impression you desire? Through the stories you tell. Let's take a simple example. Don't describe yourself as honest. Instead, tell the story about the time you, as a child, saw a \$5 bill fall from the pocket of a man walking down the street and acted quickly to reunite the lost money with its rightful owner. Your introduction is an opportunity to paint a picture of yourself through your artfully conveyed experiences.

Compile the pieces

It's time to brainstorm specific experiences that will demonstrate the impressions you've prioritized. Consider your current and any previous work, roles, projects, interests, education, and history. What anecdotes, stories, or other points of evidence could you share that would help get one or more of these ideas across? Are there other ways to illustrate them?

I'm a fan of sticky notes for times like this (alternatively, blank paper cut into small squares will also work). When I undertake this process, I start by writing an individual sticky note for each of the attributes I want to get across. Then I find myself some space: I fully clear off my desk or sit at an empty table. I've even been known to undertake this activity on the floor of my office. I position each impression sticky note so it has some empty area around it. Then I start brainstorming. I write one idea per new sticky note (typically in another color) of things to potentially include in my introduction that will help demonstrate the given ideas. This might be a mix of experiences, projects, roles, situations, anecdotes, and stories. I put each sticky close to the key impression that it best highlights (in some cases, a given experience illustrates more than one attribute, so I'll position it between categories or make a note to indicate this).

Figure 11.1 shows what this general approach looks like. I'll walk you through this process in the case study at the end of this chapter.



FIGURE 11.1 Example introduction brainstorming

Don't edit at this point; generate ideas freely. The first things that come to mind are often simple facts: jobs you've held or projects you've worked on, for example. This is a fine place to start, but I encourage you to also move beyond the contents of your resume. What has happened over the course of your life and career that will give others real insight into who you are? Determine how you can complete this thought to share an experience or tell a story starting with, "I recall a time when...." This might include:

- **Success stories:** What examples could demonstrate a job well done?
- **Turning points:** Did something happen that changed your perspective?
- **Hardships or failures:** Have you dealt with something that went really wrong?
- **Enlightening situations:** Is there a time you had an unexpected learning?
- **Challenges overcome:** Can you demonstrate your problem-solving acumen?

If you're feeling stuck, there are a few things I suggest. Talk to someone who knows you well about the impressions you want to make. Discussing it with another person may jog your memory or prompt good ideas. If you're having trouble brainstorming ideas related to your key attributes, release yourself from that constraint. Think about defining moments in your career or life. What do they say about you—do the traits they highlight align with any of the impressions you've prioritized? If not, does that indicate you've missed something important that should be added?

Don't worry about order or how it all fits together; we'll do that momentarily. By the way, if this reminds you of the storyboarding activity that we covered in Chapter 3, it should, because it's rooted in the same process. Just like we did then, once you've spent some time brainstorming, it's time to edit and arrange your ideas into a story.

Form your story

Position the output of your brainstorming process so you are able to see all of the ideas. (This is why I gravitate toward sticky notes for activities like this: they are easy to move around.) How could the various pieces you've plotted fit together? Begin to arrange.

Consider how you want to structure the overall story of you.

Do you have a single powerful story that you want to tell in detail that will demonstrate the various attributes you've prioritized? Or will it make more sense to touch upon several different elements and work to weave them together into a cohesive narrative? There isn't a right answer here; it's going to depend on your scenario and personal preference.

Determine how you'll start and end. Identify the hook or point of tension that will help you get and maintain attention. Figure out where and how it will fit with the rest of the pieces. Start a discard pile and eliminate ideas you've generated that don't fit with your planned narrative. You may have identified seven different experiences that illustrate your three prioritized impressions.

However, trying to discuss every single one of them might create a disjointed account. Determine which reasonably fit together and eliminate those that don't. Have additional sticky notes available to add greater detail when necessary and connect ideas to ensure things flow smoothly.

Introduce your company or product following these steps

This process of crafting your personal introduction could easily be used to introduce a different topic to an unfamiliar audience, too: your industry, company, or product, for example.

To recap, here are the general steps:

1. **Know your audience:** identify who they are and what they care about
2. **Identify key impressions:** prioritize the attributes you want to communicate
3. **Compile the pieces:** brainstorm what points of evidence will demonstrate them
4. **Form the story:** pull the most important pieces together into a cohesive narrative
5. **Make it great:** practice aloud, get feedback, and apply various constraints

As another twist, consider how these steps might assist your preparation for a job interview. Take time to consider your interviewers, identify key impressions, and compile the pieces. In that instance, you don't necessarily need to form it into a story. Thoughtfully weave the experiences and anecdotes you've brainstormed into your responses to interview questions posed.

When else could you make use of this activity?

Let this be a fluid and iterative process. It's not likely that you'll look at your ideas, arrange them once, and be done. You may find yourself moving things around, rearranging and assessing, adding or taking away, then rearranging some more. As you weigh which path will work best, try talking through your ideas out loud. You'll find that some combinations lend themselves more easily to this and can use that knowledge to continue to refine.

At the end of this step, you will have a rough plan of attack for your introduction. Your next goal will be to polish it.

Practice to make it great

Now that you have your general story mapped out, it's time to apply the various strategies outlined in Chapters 9 and 10. This practice will help you refine your introduction. It's also a great opportunity to improve your delivery methods in general by communicating about a topic you know quite well—yourself!

First, **practice out loud**. Start talking, using the general story you created to get the words right. If helpful, you can write it out. Rather than memorize a script, I suggest getting clear about the primary points you want to make. Then practice aloud a number of times to identify the words, phrases, and connectors that will allow you to get your ideas across and move from one to the other. As part of this, determine the specific words you'll use to start and finish. Remember that these are important elements to hit particularly well.

Seek input from others once you feel happy about how your introduction sounds. Explain your goals and ask them to imagine the perspective of your audience. If there is specific feedback you'd like about your content or delivery, share that context up front. Give your introduction as if the person evaluating you is your intended audience. Following that, have a conversation about what worked well and where you might make changes. Try not to interrupt or be defensive: listen and ask questions. Adjust based on feedback or repeat with others if helpful.

Record yourself. Watch and listen. Make observations and take note of improvements to make. Now is when you get to play with the nuances of your delivery. How will you use your body and hands? When might you alter your pace, volume, or pitch to help get your ideas and personality across? Look for low-risk situations in which to test it out (like when meeting someone new socially), and continue to modify and improve content and delivery as needed.

Hi, my name is...

To listen about the art of the introduction, check out the *storytelling with data* podcast Episode #38, “hi, my name is...”. I discuss a variation of the activities outlined here, as well as stories about and recordings of introductions from individuals on the *storytelling with data* team (storytellingwithdata.com/podcast).

When you have your robust introduction fully fleshed out and practiced, it is useful to put various time constraints on it. How would you introduce yourself if you had only two minutes? What about 30 seconds? A single sentence? Practice these versions, too. Then you’ll be ready to face basically any scenario in which you need to introduce yourself.

While I’ve outlined things as a smooth progression, you should iterate as necessary. This may mean returning to earlier steps or pulling in a prior piece later in the process. The goal is to crush your introduction and leave others with a great impression. Use the combination of tips and strategies that will enable you to do that.

You’ve planned, created, and practiced your content. You can speak about yourself eloquently. All that’s left now is to actually give your presentation!

Before we do that, let's direct our attention to the case study we've been working our way through and look at an application of the lessons learned in this penultimate chapter.

Introduce yourself: TRIX case study

My client group already knows me. Still, given the high-stakes nature of this project, I'm going to go through the full exercise of crafting my introduction. I may learn things from the process that I'll want to weave into the presentation. You never know, there may be a new face in the room when I present. With a thorough intro ready, I can pull from it and introduce myself quickly in the minutes before the meeting formally begins. Better safe than sorry. (And if things really go poorly, I will make use of it when I interview for a new job—kidding!)

I start by evaluating my audience and what impressions I'd like to create. The client team at Nosh I'll be presenting to is a mixed group. Vanessa, the Head of Product, is the person I most need to wow. She's going to have to be confident about the information I present and my abilities in general—both for the immediate decisions concerning TRIX and for determining whether to continue to work with us. I must also make a good impression on Jack, the divisional CFO; Riley, the VP of Marketing for the TRIX brand; and Charlie, who manages customer satisfaction. They will want to know that I've taken the time to understand their business and competing priorities and that I am guiding them in a prudent direction.

After taking this context into account and spending five minutes noting the various impressions I'd like to make, I compile the following list: *credible, confident, poised, articulate, trustworthy, thoughtful, smart, discerning, thorough, helpful, positive, excited, capable, experienced, considerate, supportive, collaborative, perceptive, intelligent, inquisitive, responsible, astute, professional, understanding, and empathetic.*

Next, I cull my list down to a few key impressions. In reviewing it, I note that there are a number of similar sentiments that can be grouped together (credible

and trustworthy, or smart, intelligent, and astute, for example). It also occurs to me that I am able to demonstrate some of these attributes simply through how I speak and carry myself over the course of the presentation. Confident, poised, articulate—I don't need anecdotes or experiences to illustrate these. I will show them directly through how I present. This reduces my list in ways that are helpful.

To prioritize the key impressions from what remains, I bring our ultimate goal front and center: we want to win Nosh's business for an ongoing partnership. Given this, I decide that I want most to be seen as:

- **Collaborative:** I'm helpful, inclusive, and work well with others.
- **Discerning:** I show good judgment, make smart decisions, and recommend good paths.
- **Capable:** I am experienced, ask smart questions, and identify cogent solutions.

What points of reference will help me demonstrate these attributes? I grab my sticky notes and start jotting down ideas.

As I brainstorm, I find that a number of my ideas apply to multiple attributes. Given this, I arrange the attributes (written on blue stickies) into a triangular shape to make it easier to spatially orient the experiences that relate to multiple attributes. I also realize that there are aspects of my work on the TRIX project directly that I can pull in to demonstrate some of the ideas. These will give a good sense of how we will work together going forward (in a way that is collaborative and makes use of my discerning judgment) based on how we've done so during the current project. Fifteen minutes later, I've created the following.



FIGURE 11.2 My introduction brainstorm

My brainstorming session also leads to an idea that didn't tie directly to any of the key attributes I identified but seems useful. It occurs to me: I can remember the first time I encountered a whole macadamia nut in TRIX trail mix. That's pretty powerful! I was at work. I had taken a break and grabbed a snack from the micro-kitchen. Back at my desk, absentmindedly munching, that first whole macadamia nut brought me fully into the present moment. If I can do it genuinely and without it being corny, this feels like something worth more fully exploring and perhaps using in some way. For now, I put the sticky that references the anecdote in an empty corner of the large paper on which I had arranged the output of my brainstorming process. Then I step back to consider it all.

How do I weave these ideas together? It's time to start rearranging sticky notes. I set the blue attribute stickies to the side—their job is done. Now, I want to make sure those impressions come across through how I tell my

story. I spend a few minutes unsticking, resticking, and writing additional notes, arranging everything into a gentle rise and fall mirroring the narrative arc (it comes together quickly once I take everything into account). In Figure 11.3, the yellow stickies are taken directly from my initial brainstorm; the orange ones are those I added during this formative step.

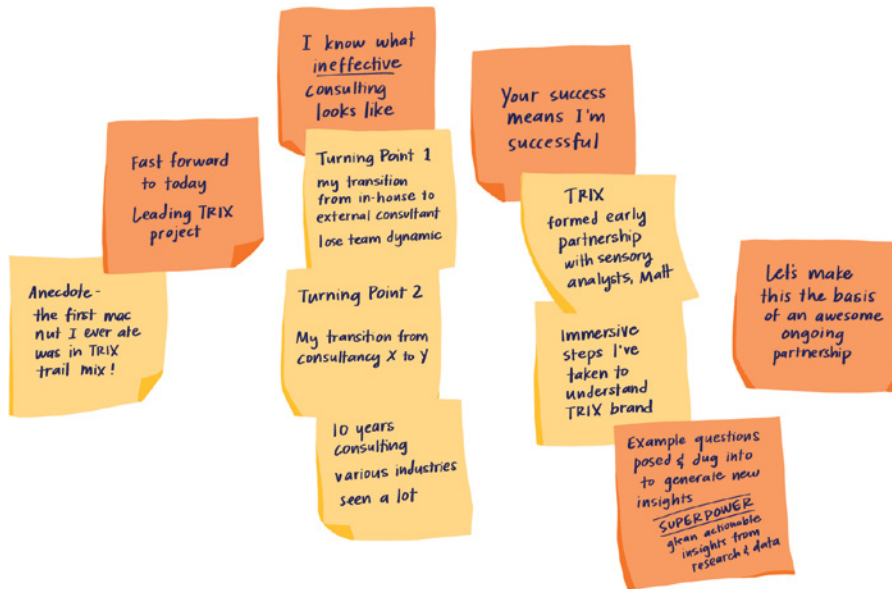


FIGURE 11.3 My introduction story

I'm going to start with my anecdote about the macadamia nut. Then I'll fast forward to today and my role on the TRIX project. If I were at a different point with the group—possibly meeting them for the first time—I would have used a past project to illustrate the ideas I want to get across. However, given that I can demonstrate them through the work we've done *on this project*, that seems like a better focus: much more relevant and convincing.

I'll introduce tension into my story by framing what an ineffective consulting-client relationship looks like, drawing on my firsthand experience during the initial years of my career. That was an awful time (and a lot of learning); I'll be able to paint a clear picture. I'll shift from there into what external

consulting looks like when it is done thoughtfully, what I've learned, and the experience I've built in the years I've been at my current company. Then I'll pivot into how I've already included this insight in my work with the Nosh team and what I've done to fully understand and appreciate the brand and its history. I think there's an opportunity to refer to some of the special findings that I'll cover more deeply in the presentation to pique interest (and highlight my team's special superpower to glean actionable insights from research and data). I'll conclude by acknowledging how amazing it's been to be driving this project and highlight my strong hope for a continued partnership with Nosh.

With my general storyline established, it's time to start talking. I practice mock introducing myself aloud a few times, using the storyboard in Figure 11.3 as my guide. Once I feel good about it, I do a dry run with my colleague, Alex, and solicit her input. Alex knows the project (you may remember her as my skilled photographer) and me well, so she will be in a good position to assess and offer valuable input.

When it comes to the structure of my story, Alex suggests introducing the interesting questions we answered about TRIX earlier and using them to lead into how I've worked with the Nosh team and built my understanding of the TRIX brand. This could be compelling; I commit to try it. She also calls me out on one of my known filler words: "So...." When I record myself delivering my intro, I keep this in mind. To my delight, I find upon viewing that not only did I not integrate any unnecessary words, but I used my hands more effectively than when I recorded previously.

Even though I probably won't use this full introduction at the onset of my presentation with the Nosh team, this exercise has been extremely valuable. It brought attention to important experiences and aspects of the way I've worked on this project that I will want to integrate into my broader presentation. I now have those instances top of mind, and I've practiced the words to fluently speak about them. I know I'll be able to work some of these ideas into conversation as part of our discussion or in response to questions. As a result of this activity, my overall presentation is going to be stronger.

Also, if there's a new face in the room, I have my quick intro ready: "Hi, I'm Cole. I like to describe my team's superpower as our ability to glean actionable insights from robust research to help brands like TRIX thrive."

Imagine *you* have just been brought into this project. How would you introduce yourself?

(Don't spend too much time—the meeting is about to start!)



have a stellar session

The date is quickly approaching: your important meeting or presentation is imminent!

This is a great point to reflect back on the various steps we've taken to get here. It all started with the planning: understanding your audience, carefully crafting your message, compiling the pieces, and then weaving it all together into a story. You created your content: first setting the style and structure of your presentation, and then filling in the specifics—thoughtfully designing slides with words, graphs, and images. As part of your preparations to deliver, you refined your content and spoken words through practice, built your confidence, and learned the art of the introduction.

We have invested a great deal of energy readying you for this. And now, *you are ready*. I have a few final tips to share: strategies to use in the days leading up to your session and in the moments before, during, and after. But more than anything, I encourage you to be fully present and enjoy yourself. You've put in a tremendous amount of effort. Now is when all of that hard work pays off.

It is time to engage people and inspire the action that you seek.

Final prep: the days leading up to your session

When you first started thinking about this project, it's possible you were facing months or weeks before your final presentation. Perhaps you've been working on it a little at a time over a long period, or maybe you've been in crunch mode trying to get everything quickly finished. Irrespective of how much time you've spent: you'll reach the point where only days (or hours!) remain between you and your session.

Envision success

Reflect on your primary goals for your meeting or presentation: what precisely do you hope to achieve? Think about success from a couple of perspectives. First, consider what you hope *for your audience*. How do you want them to feel, what do you expect to have happen, and what action should they take?

Recognize that even if people respond differently than you wish, that won't necessarily indicate that you were unsuccessful. Perhaps your audience will decide—in light of what you share or because of the insightful discussion you prompt—that another course of action is warranted. This would still be a great outcome.

Also think about success in terms of *yourself*. What do you want to experience before, during, and after your session? Given all that you've learned as you've practiced and prepared, are there things you hope to actively do or avoid?

Write down a few goals that you would like to accomplish. I'll ask you to refer back to this after you present. Your personal expectations in particular are worth recording: how you measure and judge your own success presenting in meetings, standing on stage, and in other presentation settings will change over time. Devote a journal to document your journey to storyteller, and observe your progress firsthand as you become increasingly effective.

Now that you've spent some time in self-reflection, let's figure out how to involve others.

Don't go at it alone

You may be the one responsible for some or all of the presentation, but that doesn't mean you have to do it on your own. Consider where and how you might get support from others. This can take a variety of forms; I'll list a few below.

- **Plant a friendly face in the audience.** Have a friend or your spouse attend your keynote address and sit where you are able to see them. Invite your manager to be present at your important meeting. In a virtual setting, ask a supportive colleague to join and organize your screen so they are in clear view. It's amazing what positive reinforcement a slight nod or smile from a friendly face lends while presenting.
- **Identify or develop a supporter.** Meet with select stakeholders individually ahead of time. Then you'll know who is in your court during the session. Alternatively, if someone is not supportive, meeting with them can help you better understand any resistance and work to resolve it ahead of time. In a conference setting, accomplish this through interactions with participants before your session begins.
- **Enlist a co-presenter or helper.** Line someone up to assist with the actual presentation or meeting. This could be a moderator for Q&A, an official co-presenter who will cover parts of the planned content, or someone you prep to weigh in or be ready to ask or address certain questions or discussion topics. In a virtual setting, particularly if participants can interact in various ways, it is often useful to recruit a colleague to help manage chat or lend a voice to the questions that get posed there.
- **Line someone up to give you feedback.** Identify someone who will be in attendance to offer their input afterwards (this can be someone you've also selected to play one of the previous roles described). Let them know your specific goals ahead of time. The simple act of asking for their assessment will have them rooting for you during your presentation.

Virtual setting: post a motivating picture

Sometimes even when you have supporters in the virtual environment, it's impossible to tell because either the faces on your screen are too small or you can't see your audience at all. As a substitute, post a picture of someone you'd like to make proud in your line of sight to offer encouragement in absentia: your child, parent, partner, or friend. This can both help remind you that you are speaking to people (not a computer screen) and help you feel encouraged while you do.

Before closing your eyes on the eve of your event...

Setting yourself up for success starts much earlier than twenty-four hours before an important session. That said, there are things you can do on that final day—especially during the evening—directly prior to your presentation that will have a positive impact.

Do everything in your power to ensure good, restorative rest. I recommend eating an early dinner and avoiding sugar, caffeine, and alcohol. Eating two to three hours before bedtime can drastically improve your sleep. When we eat late, it means that the muscles that digest and metabolize our food have to keep working when they could be resting. This has a negative impact on your ability to fall asleep and prevents you from getting the deep sleep you require to feel refreshed the next day.

Use some of the time between dinner and bedtime to review your materials. Before an important presentation, my routine is to have my slides be the last thing I look at before going to sleep. I advance through them on my laptop to make sure I'm clear on order and flow. I'll review my notes to myself as well: reminders on filler words to avoid, how I plan to move, and anything else I want to have top of mind for my session. I like to think (and there's some

research to back it up) that this practice helps important points move from my short-term memory to my long-term memory overnight.

This is not the time to be working on your content! I recognize that sometimes it's unavoidable: you had a less-than-ideal amount of time to get it all done and simply have to finish the deck. Even in that instance (and especially in the one where your materials are already sufficient): spend as little additional time as possible. The hours that separate you from your meeting or presentation should be focused on *you*—ensuring you'll have the energy to present powerfully—not continued tweaks or minor improvements to your slides.

Get to bed early. Also set your alarm to ensure you have ample time before your session, because there are a few things I'll suggest you do during the minutes before your presentation as well. Speaking of time, plan to wear a watch tomorrow—you're going to need it!

Wear a watch

It will be important to monitor the time leading up to and during your session. Unless you're certain there will be an easily visible clock, I highly recommend wearing a watch. A quick glance at your wrist is an unobtrusive way to check the time. Don't rely on your phone for this—you don't want to inadvertently give the impression that the possibility of an incoming text or email is more important than your audience!

Take a deep breath: it's about to start!

On the day of your session, I have a single piece of advice: arrive early. The flex time this provides can be used in a number of ways to help ensure things go well.

Arrive early

If you are able to get into the room where you'll present ahead of time, do it. Set up your equipment and assess whether there are other things to be done. I've been known to rearrange furniture—pulling a podium out of the way or situating tables or chairs to better facilitate discussion.

While I don't prefer to use a podium, I do want somewhere to set my water, coffee or tea, and notebook, so I'll work out the best place to do that. On that note, I'll also make sure I have said beverages (personally, I opt for coffee in the morning, tea in the afternoon, and always have water on hand). In a meeting room, I'll simply bring them with me and place them somewhere I can access. When presenting formally from a stage, sometimes you have the option to stash them in a podium. At an event with multiple speakers, often organizers will have bottled water available on stage.

Eat before you present—but not too much!

To keep your energy up, I recommend eating something light an hour or two before your important meeting or presentation. As was the case with spacing your dinner before sleep, it's important to allow some time between your pre-session meal and the session itself so you can direct all of your faculties to your presentation.

Depending on the length, you may need to eat during your session as well. This won't be necessary in shorter presentations (I'd avoid it to preserve professionalism). During longer sessions—for instance, a half-day

offsite or a full-day training—you should eat to maintain stamina. But not too much! Eating a large or heavy meal makes you feel sluggish. I also find that even after a small lunch during the all-day workshops that I teach, I have trouble fully catching my breath. This is the result of some of my body's attention being put toward digestion. To counter this, I've reworked post-lunch content to start with a group discussion, giving my body a little extra time before I have to be fully on again.

Walk all the way around the room to gain perspective and plot where to stand and how to move about the space if you didn't have the opportunity ahead of time. In an ideal world, you will have already run through your slides in the given venue. If that *didn't* happen and it's possible now, quickly take advantage of it (if attendees are already present, I'd suggest skipping it to avoid inadvertently starting a premature discussion).

If there is a mobile whiteboard or flipchart that you plan to draw on, move it to where you want it. When I intend to present mainly from the front of the room (and if people are generally facing frontward), I tend to opt for side-of-the-room placement if the physical space allows for it. I'll position it in the back or where I can best minimize the number of people who have to turn to see it if the audience is seated around one large table. These arrangements give me a reason and reminder to move to different parts of the room as I present or guide discussion. Use this also as an opportunity to test markers and eliminate any that might fail you when you go to emphasize a point or draw an example.

Ideally, all of this last-minute prep happens before others arrive. Once attendees begin filing into the room, chat with them. This is a great opportunity. If you already know individuals, the interaction with friendly faces can help calm nerves or give you fodder to draw on if it makes sense during the session. Introduce yourself to those with whom you aren't familiar. Work to remember or write down names if that makes sense given your scenario (acknowledging

individuals by name is an excellent way to establish rapport during the session). Use the informal time to build support and create advocates by connecting with the individuals who will comprise your audience.

Seed what you need

If there's something you will expect from an attendee, use the time before the session begins to give them a heads up. This might include if you want someone to volunteer a specific answer in response to a question, express immediate support for a position you raise, be prepared to address a certain topic, or participate in other ways. The ahead-of-time prep helps you avoid an awkward pause or unexpected response.

Take a quiet moment

Before things officially start, take a quiet moment for yourself. In a formal presentation setting, you may already have a dedicated area for this: backstage or in a green room. If not, locate a private space. I've been known to wander and find an empty conference room or office for this. If all else fails, there's always the restroom. Use this time to ground yourself.

What this looks like exactly will vary from person to person. I encourage you to establish your own routine that works for you. If you're not sure what that entails, here are some ideas.

- **Assume a power pose.** Put both hands on your hips with your shoulders back and smile. Or if you have ample space, put your arms out behind you like you're Superwoman (or Superman) flying through the air. Yes, this

sounds super silly. Yes, I've totally done it in the bathroom stall before going on stage at an important event.

- **Breathe deeply.** Take a long, deep breath in through your nose with your shoulders relaxed. Exhale slowly through your mouth, pursing your lips slightly (so it's audible) but with your jaw relaxed. Repeat several times.
- **Put things into perspective.** Look at a photo of your family, pet, or something else that brings you joy. Use it to remind yourself that this single event likely won't make or break you and that there are more important things in life.

Get ready to have some fun—it's showtime!

Have a knockout meeting or presentation

You know your stuff incredibly well. Many of the specifics of what you'll say and do live were explored deeply through the practice you undertook in Chapters 9, 10, and 11. Your job while presenting is to let all of that go—you don't have to actively think about it, because it's still in your mind and muscle memory. Simply concentrate on doing your best, connecting with people, and responding with grace to whatever comes your way.

Be in the moment

Work to stay fully present. This means fighting any urge to rush immediately into your content. Take a moment to actively notice where you are and who is around you. Breathe deeply. Smile.

You know how you're going to start because you planned and practiced it. As you progress through your content, continue to observe. This may mean pausing to invite input, interaction, or discussion or to make a quick note about something you don't want to forget if appropriate.

Nerves got the better of you? Pause and reset

I promised you that your planned start would carry you beyond your nerves. However, if this doesn't happen, all is not lost. In the situation where you find you're going too fast, having a hard time breathing, and your voice is quivering: stop. Pause. Take a drink of water. Breathe deeply to reset. Yes, it's a little awkward to do this in front of others, but it's much better to take this moment and recover from it to deliver a great presentation than to continue in a stressed-out state. The latter makes everyone uncomfortable. The former shows you're human and can even endear you to those in attendance, who may develop a heightened sense of your poise (once you regain it).

If you have a set amount of time on the meeting agenda or designated start and ends, you'll also need to keep an eye on the clock. In some scenarios, you may rely on the timing sheet you developed during your dry run. Use it to assess where you are in your content and understand whether it means making adjustments in the moment. In other cases, you're simply going to have to be aware of how long different segments are taking and move things along appropriately. Stick to your predetermined or planned time; this shows that you respect your audience.

Aren't you glad you wore that watch I suggested?

While you keep an eye on the clock, you'll also want to pay attention to others in the room. Observing reactions is a great way to gauge how things are going. Responding thoughtfully to what you see is a fantastic way to ensure things go well.

Watch and adjust

When presenting, make sure you are talking to the people in the room—not your slides. Make eye contact. When you know your content well, you can more easily observe audience cues and take action.

When you look at others in the room as you're presenting, what do you see?

Smiles and nods are positive signals that likely indicate what you're saying and how you're saying it are landing well. But what about when brows are furrowed and lips are pursed? Sometimes, people simply look that way when they are absorbing information—but it may also be a sign that they are confused about or in disagreement with something you've said. In some instances, it might make sense to pause and dig into that. Do it directly ("Chris, I think I see confusion on your face: what questions do you have?") or generally ("I think I'm observing disagreement in the room. Who can help me understand it?").

Blinded by the light

There are times—presenting formally from a stage, lights bearing down and in your face—that you can't see your audience at all. This is a challenge. In some instances, it's possible to still view those seated near the front. Use them as your visual cues to assess how things are going, but continue to look out into the audience or others will feel ignored. If you can't see anyone at all, it's similar to presenting virtually. When this happens, I'm a proponent of imagining others are smiling, nodding, and loving what you do. You don't have signals to tell you otherwise, so you may as well use this opportunity to boost your confidence while presenting!

When you are actively watching others in the room, sometimes you can catch a specific moment when attitudes change: a general relaxing of demeanors (a good thing) or a stiffening (not usually such a good thing but still a useful signal). Consider how to use this information. With less positive responses, should you do anything to address them, do something differently to keep from making it worse, or simply continue to push forward in hopes that you'll bring them around? On the brighter side, if hearts have just warmed or credibility was gained, is that enough to carry you through, or will you lean into the actions or words that helped you make it happen?

Speaking of leaning: that's another way to read your audience. As we noted in Chapter 10, leaning in signals interest (unless a hand is aggressively on the table or a finger is out—these typically indicate that the person wants to say something!). Leaning back is a sign of confidence, though read this one carefully, since it can also signal feelings of dislike or negativity (this is a subconscious response; we are naturally inclined to try to distance ourselves from things that are unpleasant) or indifference.

Another sign of indifference—or, taking things a step further, *disinterest*—is when an audience member visibly turns their attention to something else. When someone starts rifling through papers in front of them, opens their laptop and begins to type, or picks up their phone and starts scrolling: you've lost them. Their actions speak loudly. When you observe this happening, you have to decide whether you're going to do anything about it. This obviously depends on the situation and who the person is. Your course of action (or lack thereof) will be different if it is a couple of people in a big presentation compared to a key stakeholder who you need to have engaged.

This is one of the reasons I suggested you stand while presenting. It affords you some effective tricks. To address the disengaged stakeholder, walking to near where they are seated and continuing to talk from there can sometimes lead to a laptop being shut or phone being set down. It's uncomfortable for an individual to be focused on something else when they know that you—the speaker—are close and that all eyes are looking in that direction.

Podium pet peeves

While I generally like to teach by framing things positively—proactive things you can do to improve or be more effective—sharing what doesn't work well also lends insight. You want to connect with your audience. Don't let potential irritations impair your ability to do so. With that in mind, here are some of my personal presenter pet peeves.

Please *don't*...

- **Start with “Can you hear me?”** Work this out ahead of time.
- **Now that we've established the microphone is working...use it poorly.** Your audience doesn't want to listen to your p's popping, but they do want to hear you clearly. When using a handheld mic, this generally means holding it close to, but not touching, your mouth. Test and adjust hands-free microphones before you start to ensure they don't rub noisily against clothing or hair.
- **Stand behind the podium.** Don't let a physical barrier come between you and others! Step out from behind the podium (or rearrange the furniture ahead of time to remove obstacles in your way). Don't let anything block your face. Ensure people have a clear line of sight so they can connect with you.
- **Dishonor your audience.** This can take a variety of forms: making an obscure reference that only a portion of attendees will know or relate to or telling them something generally known as if it were novel are a couple examples. Watch for things you say or do that could be interpreted by your audience to signal that you don't understand them.
- **Call attention to technical difficulties.** Either it wasn't obvious, in which case you've now pointed it out to them, or it was blatant and they were already aware. There's no reason to emphasize the issue.

- **Read your notes.** You cannot connect with others when you do this! It's also a credibility killer because it gives the impression that you aren't comfortable with your content. It's fine to refer to a note now and then (for example, to remind yourself of a specific reference or read a quote), but in general, avoid reading from notes or slides.
- **Make self-deprecating comments.** Your audience would like to be confident in you. If you aren't self-assured, that makes it difficult for them.
- **End with "That's it" or "That's what I have for you."** As we discussed in Chapter 9, plan a powerful close, reinforcing salient points and leaving people inspired and ready to act.

There are additional actions you can take (particularly if the disengagement you've observed is with more than a tiny fraction of those in attendance). Use your voice—or lack of voice. If you've been talking, talking, talking...

Simply...stop.

The shift from constant chatter to silence is attention garnering. The other means of audible contrast that we discussed in Chapter 10 can also be used: slow down, speed up, make a point LOUDLY to get people to tune in. Use your hands in a grand gesture. Run into the audience!

Connect with people

Well, okay, probably don't run into the audience. Though I have actually done something similar before—I *stepped off* of the stage into the crowd during a large conference presentation. It wasn't to get others to engage; they were already paying attention. I had been building to a crescendo and wanted

to impart this pivotal moment in the same physical space with everyone. This broke the invisible barrier in an interesting way. And it meant I could really see faces, make eye contact, and connect.

I brought my audience into my presentation by going to them. Another way to relate is to bring them (figuratively) to you: invite interaction. This can take many different forms and will vary widely depending on your situation. It might be handled via questions addressed in the moment or discussion that happens over the course of your meeting. Encourage people to shout out short responses in a large group or have a microphone runner who helps amplify voices and ideas. You can integrate interactive polls or invite attendees to share thoughts via chat in your virtual presentation. Look for ways to include your audience—they will be more engaged and attentive. In the event that decisions are being made, they will be more bought in, too.

If someone raises a topic or poses a question that you know you are going to want to redirect to someone else who is present, acknowledge it: “That’s a great question, Sarah! Brian, I’m going to turn to you momentarily so you can let us know your thoughts. Before I do that, I’ll tell you my immediate reaction.” This is especially effective in a virtual setting, where it’s possible that Brian got distracted by his email. Calling him out by name and warning him that you’re turning things over to him soon gets his attention back and provides him a moment to collect his thoughts.

I’ve framed this instance as having a more intimate setting, where you know the individuals. A variation of this works in other scenarios as well. Imagine a workshop setting where someone poses a question that I want to use to invite additional interaction. I could respond with something like, “Great point. I’d like to hear some experiences from the group. First, I’ll share one that comes to my mind....” This gives people the time both to think about whether they have something to contribute and to gather their courage to speak up. Or if I want to give *myself* some time to think, I can flip this around: “That’s an excellent question. Before I lend my thoughts, I’m going to open it up to the room—what do others think?”

Addressing questions

I've mentioned one strategy I sometimes use when facing questions. I've also been known to respond to off-the-wall questions with a redirect. "That's an interesting thought. Another question people commonly have about this topic is...." That won't always be appropriate, but it is another trick to have up your sleeve as you try to maintain order when fielding queries. For more tips and strategies related to handling Q&A sessions and eloquently responding to questions in general, check out the *storytelling with data* podcast Episode 46, "questions about questions" (storytellingwithdata.com/podcast).

Respond gracefully to the unexpected

I've seen Murphy's Law play out time after time in my own meetings, workshops, and presentations: if anything can go wrong, it will. While this may seem like a pessimistic observation, I don't view it that way. I appreciate the unexpected things that arise—these are instances that help keep me in the moment, on my toes, and learning.

While you might be totally flustered on the inside while trying to figure out how to handle the situation, magic is created when you project calmness—in spite of the troubles—to others. Further, if you *look* composed, it helps you start to feel that way, too. Take a deep breath, then consider a feasible course of action. Here are some tactics I've used over time:

- **Smile, recognize it, and move on.** I once fully tripped on a cord while on stage. In one moment, I was walking and talking; in the following, I was flat on the floor, handheld microphone bouncing loudly across the stage. What to do?! I took a moment to try to regain my composure (impossible on the inside, but I deliberately put on a brave face), stood up, took the

microphone from the nice man who grabbed it for me, and paused. I took a deep breath, smiled at my audience, and said sarcastically, “You’ve just witnessed my impeccable grace.” Then I resumed my presentation from where I left off. (This is the primary reason I now have blue tape in my presenter pack—my heels won’t catch on cords that are properly taped down!)

- **Solicit help.** Midway through an important meeting, my computer crashed and refused to come back to life. Fortunately, one of my colleagues was also in attendance. I borrowed his computer and asked him to take control of the room by facilitating an impromptu discussion while I downloaded my slides (which were luckily saved to the cloud) until I was ready to resume.
- **Change your plans.** On an occasion that I touched upon previously, I was about to start a workshop but was having trouble getting the projector to work. Several others tried to help without success. The AV guy—who was apparently the only one who knew how to run it—wasn’t available, so it was clear I would have to begin the session without my slides. This highlights another great reason to arrive early. In the minutes before start time, I was able to reorganize my content, starting with a topic that didn’t rely heavily on slides and drawing on the whiteboard when visual aid was crucial. When tech support finally arrived, we took a break and got the slides up and running for the rest of the session.
- **Improvise.** In another instance, I was preparing to facilitate an interactive off-site session for a group of 100. The multi-page handouts I had emailed ahead of time to be printed for the day that contained our hands-on exercises had been forgotten at the office 60 miles away. I sent one of the organizers to the nearby copy and print store with the handouts on a thumb drive, another to locate blank paper to pass out to attendees, and then set to work creating additional slides to direct the hands-on activities until the hard copies arrived.
- **Provide another solution.** In a virtual training session, we once encountered tech issues that prevented some participants from joining until halfway through the hour. To make up for it, we offered them a spot in a future session and also provided video content that covered the concepts that were missed.

- **Reschedule.** There are times when the session simply can't go on as planned. We can't control or fix everything. A critical stakeholder can't attend, the video conferencing application has an outage, the power goes out. In these extreme cases, rescheduling may be the best option.

When things do go awry, don't dwell on it. Also try not to let it impact the rest of your session.

The unexpected comes in many flavors. I've shared some anecdotes of things gone wrong, but there are also instances where the scenario simply isn't what you anticipated. For example, you're planning to start your keynote presentation by introducing yourself, then the person who you thought was simply going to say your name and hand you the microphone gives a full rundown of your background before doing so. Ideally, you'll know ahead of time whether to expect this. Otherwise, you need to think on your feet and decide how to respond. You might skip your intro altogether and jump straight into content. Or make the succession of events appear purposeful with an additive statement: "That was a great overview. I do want to tell you a little more about myself, but I'm going to do it in a different way..." (and then launch into the story of you as you intended).

As another case of things going a little differently than planned, I was once getting ready to deliver a keynote session. Directly before I went on stage, the organizer asked everyone to get out their phone to take a picture of a QR code that was projected on the screen and complete a brief survey. *Aargh!* The *last* thing I wanted to do was begin my presentation while everyone was distracted on their phone. I had to determine quickly how to get their attention back. I walked out onto the stage and stood dead center, silent. I looked out at the audience, smiling, for what was probably an awkward amount of time. But it worked. Phones were put away and eyes were directed to me. When I launched in with my powerful planned start, I had their full attention.

These situations—and others like them—can cause some discomfort. You may experience bad feelings simply reading about them or thinking about the various aspects of your own presentations that could take unexpected turns. I like

to think of this as *productive discomfort*. If you can get comfortable being a little uncomfortable, you will be able to respond to any scenario that arises (or at least the majority of them!) with eloquence.

Embrace the unexpected. It's when some of your most transformational presentation moments will happen.

Time to reflect—and refine for next time!

You did it: you were present in the moment, you watched your audience and adjusted, you connected with people, and you responded elegantly to the unexpected. You are finished giving your presentation!

The hard work is complete, but you are not done. There isn't an end point to being a skilled presenter. Every presentation is another opportunity to try something new, learn, and improve.

After your session is over, take a few moments to reflect. Did the things you hoped would take place happen? Look back at the goals you outlined for yourself ahead of time. Were you successful? What learnings or refinements will you pull forward into forthcoming presentations? Connect with the person you identified to give you feedback. See whether and how this changes your perception and goals. Set your plan for your next presentation. And then do it all again!

As you think about the future, let's take one final look back—to the case study we've been working our way through.

Have a stellar session: TRIX case study

You've accompanied me along quite a journey as I planned, created, and prepared to deliver my presentation to the client team at Nosh. As I write these words, that final presentation is already behind me. Months of analysis, followed by weeks of preparation—all that work culminated in a single critical hour that felt like it flew by in an instant.

How did the meeting go? I'll let you judge for yourself. Watch it at storytellingwithyou.com/finale. You can also view my slide deck on the following pages.

My final words to you (for now) as you plan, create, and deliver: strive to continually refine and improve. Here's to your next presentation. Make it a stellar one!